



CITY: Pg 2

Maths teacher in cop net for aiding Bishnoi gang's ₹10 cr extortion bid



NATION: Pg 5

Cong links Yadav aides' exit to 'gigantic scandal'



FILM: Pg 12

'It's important that people know me for my work'

UNVEIL BROAD ROADMAP FOR STRONGER INDIA-AUSTRALIA RELATIONS

Modi, Albanese seal 18 deals spanning defence, nuclear energy, trade & tech



Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese during a community programme, in Melbourne on Thursday

MPOST BUREAU

MELBOURNE: Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese on Thursday unveiled an ambitious expansion of the India-Australia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, signing 18 agreements and initiatives spanning defence, civil nuclear energy, maritime security, critical technologies, education, trade and clean energy. The summit in Melbourne also produced a renewed commitment to accelerate negotiations on the proposed Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement (CECA) and a bilateral investment treaty, while both leaders underlined their shared vision for a peaceful, stable and rules-based Indo-Pacific amid growing regional security challenges.

Following the talks, Modi said the partnership between the two countries had made

CLOSER LOOK

- » Modi, Albanese expand Comprehensive Strategic Partnership during Melbourne summit
- » Both nations fast-track Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement and investment treaty negotiations
- » Civil nuclear pact clears commercial uranium exports from Australia to India
- » New defence declaration replaces 2009 security cooperation framework

remarkable progress since the Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement came into force in 2022. "Held wide-ranging discussions with Prime Minister

- » Maritime Security Roadmap boosts Indo-Pacific coordination, interoperability and information sharing
- » Coast guards sign pact on maritime law enforcement and border security
- » Cyber, critical technologies and supply chains partnership launched
- » India, Australia to collaborate on critical minerals corridor
- » Energy security statement strengthens cooperation on reliable fuel supplies

Albanese in Melbourne this afternoon. The India-Australia Comprehensive Strategic Partnership has continuously expanded the scope of our cooperation. Continued on P4

'Grow More, Achieve More driving India's development journey'

MELBOURNE: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday said India is moving towards becoming a developed nation with the vision of "Grow More, Achieve More", driven by the aspirations of its 1.4 billion people. Addressing the Indian diaspora in Melbourne, he highlighted rapid economic growth, digital progress, manufacturing expansion and innovation. Modi also cited advances in defence, space and start-ups, while describing the Indian community as a vital bridge strengthening India-Australia ties. See P5

US, Iran exchange fresh strikes as ceasefire teeters

Raises fears of wider regional conflict

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: The United States carried out a new wave of airstrikes across Iran on Thursday, prompting Tehran to launch retaliatory missile and drone attacks against US-allied countries in the Middle East, further weakening a fragile ceasefire and raising concerns that the region could slide back into a wider war.

The latest exchange came after US President Donald Trump declared the ceasefire was effectively "over" following Iran's alleged attacks on commercial ships in the Strait of Hormuz. The renewed fighting has renewed fears over the security of one of the world's busiest energy routes, through which around one-fifth of globally traded oil and natural gas passed before the conflict began with US and Israeli strikes on February 28.

Air raid sirens sounded several times in Bahrain, home to the US Navy's Fifth Fleet headquarters, while missiles also targeted Kuwait and Qatar. Sirens were also

TAKEAWAYS

- » US launched fresh airstrikes on around 90 targets across Iran on Thursday
- » Iran retaliated with missiles and drones targeting Bahrain, Kuwait and Qatar
- » US strikes hit Chabahar port for the first time since April

activated in Jordan, where US troops and aircraft are stationed.

Kuwait's military said it intercepted three ballistic missiles, a cruise missile and 10 drones. Falling debris injured one person. Bahrain said it had shot down incoming projectiles but did not provide further details. There were no immediate reports of damage in Qatar.

The US military's Central Command (CENTCOM) said it struck around 90 targets across Iran in what it described as an effort to further reduce Tehran's ability to threaten shipping in the Strait of Hormuz. Continued on P4

Kashmir schools asked to screen all books to identify objectionable content

NARESH BISWANI

SRINAGAR: The Jammu and Kashmir administration has directed all government schools, recognised private schools and coaching centres across the Kashmir division to screen every book on their premises for "inappropriate or objectionable content", following concerns over the circulation of literature allegedly containing anti-national and separatist material in educational institutions.

Under a circular issued by the Directorate of School Education Kashmir (DSEK), heads of institutions have been asked to examine all books, whether newly acquired or older publications, kept in school libraries, classrooms, staff rooms and offices. The exercise is intended to ensure that no publication contains material that violates religious sentiments, is unsuitable for students, contravenes prevailing

The order covers all educational institutions under the Directorate, including 10,787 government schools and 2,386 recognised private schools in the Kashmir division

Continued on P4

IMD WARNS OF MORE HEAVY RAIN

Monsoon fury batters several states, 10 dead in rain-related incidents



Commuters make their way through a waterlogged road following heavy rain, in the Gazipur area of New Delhi, on Thursday morning

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: More than 10 people were confirmed dead in rain-related incidents across India on Thursday as torrential monsoon showers caused floods, landslides, building collapses and widespread waterlogging in several states. Roads were submerged, trees uprooted, homes and infrastructure damaged, and traffic was disrupted as authorities worked to restore normalcy. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) warned that heavy rainfall is likely to continue in many parts of the country.

Delhi witnessed one of its heaviest spells of rain this season, with some areas receiving more than 160 mm of rainfall. The showers flooded roads, disrupted traffic and helped the city record its cleanest air since September 2023. The death toll in a building collapse in Rohini rose to three. Waterlogging affected areas including Vikas Marg, Munirka, Sangam

Vihar, Dwarka, Burari, Badarpur, Alipur and the New Delhi railway station area.

Traffic slowed on ITO, Ring Road, NH-48, Mehrauli-Badarpur Road, Rohtak Road, Punjabi Bagh and Shadipur. In Alipur, several trucks and cars were partially submerged. The Delhi Fire Service reported multiple incidents of trees falling in East of Kailash, Kalkaji-Govindpuri, Dhingra Marg and Ranjeet Nagar.

In Gujarat, floodwaters in Surat began receding after heavy rain a day earlier. Six more bodies were recovered, taking the rain-related death toll in the city over the past few days to 17. Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel visited Surat to review the situation.

Rescue efforts continued at a waste-to-energy plant in Pimpri Chinchwad near Pune after a building collapsed when a massive garbage mound gave way during heavy rain. One body was recovered on Thursday, nine people have

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Delhi records over 160 mm rain in parts, widespread flooding and three building collapse deaths
- » Heavy waterlogging cripples traffic across Delhi, Noida, Ghaziabad and other NCR cities
- » Surat rain death toll reaches 17 as floodwaters gradually recede across the city
- » One body recovered in Pune plant collapse; around eight people remain trapped
- » Seven die in Uttar Pradesh due to lightning, wall collapses and drowning incidents

been rescued, and around eight others are still feared trapped. In Thane, a 64-year-old man who was injured after a tree fell during heavy rain died.

Uttar Pradesh reported seven rain-related deaths. Two women died after lightning struck them in separate villages of Sant Kabir Nagar, while a 14-year-old boy was killed by lightning in Kushinagar. Two people died and four were injured when a wall collapsed onto makeshift tents in Bulandshahr. In Shamli, a man died and his two sons were seriously injured after the wall of a tin shed collapsed. In Ghaziabad, a three-year-old girl drowned after being swept into a waterlogged drain outside her home.

The IMD issued a red alert for parts of western Uttar Pradesh and said widespread rainfall is expected across the state until July 11.

Fresh floods and landslides were reported in six districts of Arunachal Pradesh, including Keyi Panyor, Upper Continued on P4

EMOTIONAL SEND-OFF



The flower petal-covered coffin of the late Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei is carried above mourners reaching out to touch it outside the Imam Hussein Shrine in Karbala, Iraq, early Thursday

Hours after joining BJP, ex-TMC trio gets Rajya Sabha tickets

Former TMC MPs Yusuf Pathan & Shatabdi Roy meet CM Suwendu

PRADIP CHATTERJEE

KOLKATA: In a political crossover and a development that had long been speculated, hours after formally joining the BJP, former Trinamool Congress (TMC) Rajya Sabha members — Sushmita Dev, Sukhendu Sekhar Ray and Prakash Chik Baraik were named as the BJP's candidates for the upcoming bypoll elections for Rajya Sabha.

The three leaders joined the BJP weeks after resigning from the Rajya Sabha and quitting

the TMC amid growing dissent within the party. Welcoming them with BJP flags, state president Samik Bhattacharya said their vast parliamentary and political experience would strengthen the party. "In this changed political situation, three distinguished Members of the Rajya Sabha—Shri Sukhendu Sekhar Ray, Smt. Sushmita Dev and Shri Prakash Chik Baraik—have resigned from their membership of the Rajya Sabha and are formally joining the BJP today," Bhattacharya stated. Continued on P4

WhatsApp submits reply on 'username'

NEW DELHI: Meta-owned WhatsApp has submitted its response to the Centre's notice over its proposed "username" feature, and the Information Technology Ministry is examining the reply, sources said on Thursday. The government had issued the notice on July 1, raising concerns that the feature could lead to more online fraud, phishing, digital arrest scams and impersonation attacks. The feature would allow users to communicate without sharing their phone numbers. The Centre had directed WhatsApp not to launch it until consultations were completed to the government's satisfaction. Continued on P4

BSNL announces satellite phone for Rs 1.34 lakh

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: State-run BSNL on Thursday announced the availability of a satellite phone priced at Rs 1,34,166 including all taxes, as it expands satellite communication services for defence, maritime, disaster response and other users operating in remote locations.

In a post on X, BSNL said the satellite phone supports voice calls and SMS services in areas where conventional mobile networks are unavailable. "When conventional mobile networks can't reach, the BSNL Satellite Phone keeps you connected," the company said, adding that the device is designed for Continued on P4

NASHIK: A Nashik court has granted bail to pregnant accused Nida Khan in a case involving alleged sexual harassment and religious conversion at a TCS office, observing that forcing a woman to give birth in prison would cause unbearable trauma. In a detailed order made available on Thursday, Additional Sessions Judge K G Joshi said, "The trauma of giving birth in a prison like Lord Krishna or the related social stigma is not bearable for anyone." The court, while noting that Khan was five months pregnant, said judicial discretion should be exercised in her favour for the welfare of both the mother and the unborn child. Bail had been granted on July 6. The court directed Khan's release on a personal bond of Rs 75,000 with one solvent surety of the same amount. It also noted that the investigation was complete and the charge sheet had already been filed, making Continued on P4

RAM TEMPLE DONATION THEFT

Probe finds stolen funds invested, lent on interest, routed through relatives

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: The investigation into the alleged theft of donations at the Ram temple in Ayodhya has uncovered a suspected network of financial transactions in which stolen money was allegedly invested in the stock market, lent on interest and routed through the bank accounts of relatives and close associates to hide its source, according to police sources. Investigators said bank transaction records have supported this pattern of fund transfers. Police have frozen 30 bank

accounts linked to relatives of the accused and are examining the financial trail to determine the extent of the alleged money laundering and identify everyone who benefited.

Three accused, Anukalp Mishra, Lavkush Mishra and Karunesh Pandey, are on police remand after being brought from the district jail on Wednesday following court permission. During questioning, they allegedly admitted to the theft and shared details of how the operation was carried out. Continued on P4

THOUSANDS OF INDIAN STUDENTS AWAIT

Fall admissions under cloud as US silent on extra student visa slots

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: As thousands of Indian students prepare to begin their higher education in the US this fall, uncertainty over student visa interview appointments continues to fuel concerns about reaching campuses before classes begin.

Responding to queries over the issue, US authorities said the United States "welcomes foreign citizens who come to the US to study" and outlined the student visa application process. However, they did not say whether additional visa interview slots would be opened in the coming weeks. Officials said students must first



secure admission to an accredited educational institution, which issues Form I-20, a mandatory document for applying for a student visa.

According to the US authorities, first-time applicants for F and M cat-

KEY POINTS

- » Entry is allowed only 30 days before course commencement
- » US gives no timeline for additional interview appointments
- » F-1 visas cover academic programmes
- » M-1 visas are for vocational courses

egory visas can receive their visas up to one year before the start of their academic programme. However, they can enter the US only within 30 days of the programme start date mentioned Continued on P4

'35-YEAR-OLD AIDED GANGSTERS' RECONNAISSANCE OPERATION'

Maths teacher in cop net for aiding Bishnoi gang's ₹10 cr extortion bid

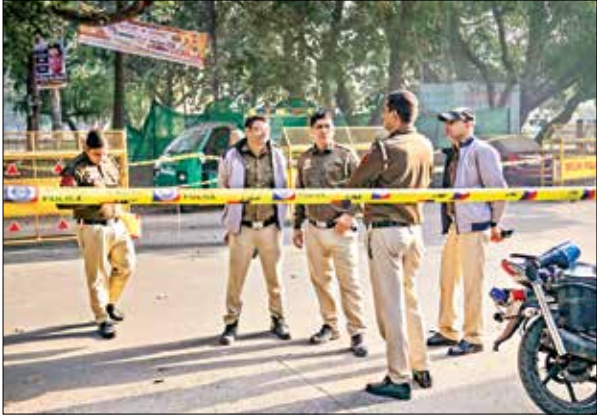
OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A B'Tech graduate who taught Maths in coaching centres was arrested for allegedly aiding the Hari Boxer-Lawrence Bishnoi gang by conducting a recce of a businessman whom they tried to extort, police said on Thursday.

The accused, identified as Amit Bishnoi alias Rudra Pratap Singh (35), originally from Haryana's Hisar, had been teaching Mathematics at various coaching centres in Mukherjee Nagar since 2018, they said.

According to Delhi Police Special Cell, Singh allegedly conducted a recce of the victim's office, recorded a video of the premises and shared it with gangster Hari Boxer, who later used the footage while threatening the businessman and demanding Rs 10 crore.

"On June 15, the business-



man, a resident of Mukherjee Nagar, received a social media call from an international number. The caller, who identified himself as Hari Boxer, threatened to kill the businessman and his children if the money was not paid within a week," Deputy Commissioner of Police (Special Cell) Praveen Kumar Tripathi said

in a statement.

Tripathi said the gangster subsequently contacted the victim through multiple foreign numbers and also shared a video of his office to demonstrate that the gang had gathered detailed information about him.

"The caller warned that the businessman would be 'blown

HIGHLIGHTS

- » 'The caller warned that the businessman would be 'blown up' if he failed to meet the demand,' the DCP said
- » The businessman filed a complaint at the Mukherjee Nagar police station, following which an FIR was registered on July 8, and an investigation was launched

up' if he failed to meet the demand," the DCP said.

The businessman filed a complaint at the Mukherjee Nagar police station, following which an FIR was registered on July 8, and an investigation was launched.

During the probe, the Special Cell apprehended Singh, who allegedly admitted to col-

lecting information about the victim, his family and business at the behest of Hari Boxer, police said.

Police said Singh came in contact with jailed gangster Lawrence Bishnoi through a common acquaintance in Haryana in 2014. He later established contact with Hari Boxer, who allegedly recruited him to provide local logistical support and intelligence for the extortion operation.

Police are probing whether Singh helped the gang identify other potential targets in Delhi and whether he was involved in similar reconnaissance activities in the past.

They said Amit Bishnoi is a B'Tech graduate from Haryana's Faridabad and had prepared for UPSC and SSC exams in Mukherjee Nagar. Since 2018, he had been working as a Maths teacher in various coaching centres in the area.

Cops seek recall of raw eggs & TV relief for riots accused

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has moved a court here seeking recall or modification of an order that allowed 2020 Delhi riots accused Shahrulk Pathan to receive four raw eggs daily and keep a separate television in his high-security prison cell, saying the directions require reconsideration.

Pathan has been accused of pointing a gun at a police constable during the riots.

The plea has been filed against an order passed by Additional Sessions Judge Sameer Bajpai on June 4 after the counsel of the accused submitted that his client, who is lodged in the Tihar Jail, is facing frustration and depression due to prolonged incarceration.

In the June 4 order, the court allowed an application moved by Pathan seeking four raw eggs every day instead of boiled eggs and permission to have a separate television in his cell at his own expense.

Pathan's counsel had argued that boiled eggs did not suit him and made him ill. The



Pathan is facing trial in a case arising out of the 2020 northeast Delhi riots and is currently lodged in judicial custody

defence had also submitted that since Pathan was lodged in a separate cell as a high-risk inmate, he was unable to watch television programmes of his choice on the common TV meant for multiple prisoners, adding that prolonged incarceration had left him frustrated and depressed.

Accepting the request, the court directed the Tihar Jail

superintendent to provide Pathan four raw eggs every day instead of boiled eggs. The court also permitted him to have a separate television to be purchased using his own funds, and directed the jail authorities to comply with the order.

Police have now approached the court seeking recall or modification of those directions. The plea is yet to be decided.

Pathan is facing trial in a case arising out of the 2020 northeast Delhi riots and is currently lodged in judicial custody. Other accused in the case are on bail.

The case arises out of an FIR registered at Jafraabad Police Station in connection with the riots that broke out in northeast Delhi in February 2020.

Pathan had allegedly pointed a gun at Police Constable Deepak Dahiya during the violence, an incident that gained widespread attention after photographs of the act went viral on social media.

He was arrested on March 3, 2020 and has remained in judicial custody since then.

NOIDA: Three dead as speeding car hits labourers walking home

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: Three migrant labourers from Bihar were killed after a speeding Scorpio SUV allegedly ran them over while they were returning on foot from paddy fields in Jewar late on Wednesday night, police said.

The deceased were identified as Karan, Vishwajeet and Mithun, all residents of Jamua village under Tarabari police station in Bihar's Araria district. The trio had travelled to Neemka village in Gautam Buddh Nagar to work as seasonal agricultural labourers during the paddy transplantation season.

According to police, the labourers had spent the day transplanting paddy in fields at Neemka village. After completing their shift late on Wednesday night, they began walking back to the village along the



According to police, the labourers had spent the day transplanting paddy in fields

rushed to the spot and shifted the victims to Kailash Hospital in Jewar, where doctors declared them brought dead.

Jewar Station House Officer Ajay Kumar Singh said the victims had been engaged in paddy transplantation work in Neemka village and were returning after work when the accident occurred.

Police conducted the inquest proceedings and sent the bodies for post-mortem examination. The victims' families in Bihar have been informed.

A case has been registered and efforts are underway to identify and trace the Scorpio driver. Police are examining CCTV footage from the surrounding area and collecting evidence to establish the exact sequence of events. Further legal action will be taken based on the findings of the investigation.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court has held that the ED cannot issue a summons to alleged real estate fraud accused Amit Katyal's residence in the national capital as a valid service on his son Krishan Katyal, saying the agency must follow the due process prescribed by law for serving a person living abroad.

Additional Sessions Judge Sheetal Chaudhary Pradhan was hearing an application filed by Amit Katyal seeking directions restraining the Enforcement Directorate (ED) from treating the summons served at his address as valid service on his son and requested that the agency be directed to follow the legal procedure for serving a foreign national residing overseas.

In an order dated July 8, the court said, "Krishan Katyal

is not a citizen of India and is not an accused in the predicate offence. The service of summons at the address of the applicant dated August 1, 2025 and August 19, 2025 cannot be a deemed service and therefore is non est in law and the ED was required to follow due process of law and serve Krishan Katyal as per procedure established."

The court also said that Krishan Katyal is not an accused either in the money laundering case or in the scheduled offence being investigated by the ED. "There were categorical submission on behalf of applicant to ED vide its letter through counsel dated August 12, 2025 and August 30, 2025 and considering that son of the accused, Krishan Katyal does not reside and has never resided since 2017 at the address of the applicant, could not have been served at the address of the applicant," it said.



The latest probe pertains to allegations of non-delivery of flats in Gurugram's Krrish Florence Estate

Earlier on November 19 last year, the agency arrested Amit Katyal, a real estate businessman considered close to RJD chief Lalu Prasad's family, in a money laundering case linked to alleged cheating of homebuyers in Gurugram.

Amit Katyal was taken into

custody by the Gurugram zonal office of the agency under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). He was arrested by the ED in 2023 too in a separate money laundering case related to the railways' alleged land-for-jobs scam involving Prasad, his wife Rabri Devi and other family members.

He later obtained bail in the case. The latest investigation pertains to the allegations of non-delivery of flats in the Krrish Florence Estate built over 14 acres in Gurugram's Sector 70. The project was being developed by Amit Katyal's company, Angle Infrastructure Pvt Ltd.

According to the ED, Amit Katyal obtained a licence from another developer in a "fraudulent" manner and started collecting funds from prospective buyers much before the grant of licence from DTCP (Direc-

torate of Town and Country Planning) Haryana, leading to the generation of "proceeds of crime" worth Rs 300 crore.

Probe found several "fraudulent" bookings made by Amit Katyal to third parties in a project meant for central government employees and "diversion" of funds for other purposes leading to stalling of the project.

The agency accused Amit Katyal of "alienating" a part of the licensed land of two acres valued at Rs 130 crore at under-valued rates to third parties during the insolvency proceedings, calling it a "clear abuse of the process of law under the IBC (Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code)".

The ED alleged Amit Katyal diverted public sector bank loans, causing an Rs 80 crore loss, and chargedseemed him in a separate Rs 500 crore homebuyers' fraud case.

26-year-old dies after drowning in school pool

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 26-year-old man allegedly drowned while swimming at the pool of Bholi Ram Public School in Delhi's Najafgarh area on Wednesday evening, police said.

The deceased was identified as Rahul Rai, also known as Rahul Roy, a resident of Jharoda village. Police said he had gone to the swimming pool with his friends — Suraj Singh, Tarun Kumar and Bhavishya — when the incident occurred at around 5.30 pm.

A PCR call alerted Najafgarh police after Rahul was taken unconscious to Tarak Hospital, where doctors declared him brought dead. Police said Rahul worked with a private company, Interval India, in the packaging of cardboard cartons.

The body has been shifted to Rao Tula Ram Memorial (RTRM) Hospital for post-mortem examination. Police have inspected the swimming pool and the surrounding area, while statements of Rahul's friends and other witnesses are being recorded to reconstruct the sequence of events.

A case has been registered under Section 106(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. Investigators are also examining the safety arrangements at the swimming pool to determine whether any negligence contributed to the incident. The post-mortem report is awaited to ascertain the exact cause of death. Police said no foul play has been established so far.

Desilting completed in East, South, North Zones: DDA

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has completed the desilting of storm water drains in the East, South and North Zones, while work in the Narela, Rohini and Dwarka Zones is in its final stages as part of its monsoon preparedness drive.

The exercise, undertaken in mission mode under the supervision of Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu, aims to strengthen the city's drainage infrastruc-

ture ahead of the peak monsoon season.

According to the DDA, the Lieutenant Governor has been regularly reviewing the preparedness of various agencies and closely monitoring the progress of desilting operations to ensure residents do not face inconvenience during heavy rainfall. Acting on these directions, field-level execution was expedited and progress was monitored on a regular basis.

To streamline the exercise, Delhi was divided into six operational zones — East,

DDA has also set up a Central Flood Control Room

South, North, Narela, Rohini and Dwarka — enabling focused planning, close supervision and timely execution.

The authority said more than 57,000 metric tonnes (MT) of silt have been removed from storm water drains this year, compared with around 33,380 MT during last year's pre-monsoon drive, mark-

ing an increase of over 70 per cent. The pre-monsoon desilting is expected to significantly improve the carrying capacity of the drainage network and ensure smoother flow of rainwater.

As part of its flood management strategy, the DDA has set up a Central Flood Control Room along with flood control rooms in all engineering zones. A dedicated 24x7 helpline is also being established for the prompt redressal of waterlogging-related complaints, while mobile pumping units have

been deployed at identified vulnerable locations.

The authority said several preventive measures have also been undertaken, including drain cleaning, strengthening drainage infrastructure, installing pumping arrangements, ensuring the immediate disposal of desilted material and continuous monitoring of vulnerable stretches. These measures are aimed at improving drainage efficiency, minimising waterlogging and facilitating smoother traffic movement during the monsoon.

HC seeks Centre's reply on Ambassador Hotel eviction plea

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Thursday sought the stand of the central government on a petition by the Ambassador Hotel owner against a show-cause notice for eviction from the 7.58-acre premises at Sujan Singh Park here.

Justice Harish Vaidyanathan Shankar issued notice on the petition by Sir Sobha Singh and Sons Private Limited and granted three weeks to the Centre to file its reply.

Senior counsel for the petitioner said he apprehended that an order of eviction could be passed on July 10. The matter has been listed before the estate officer on this date.

He urged the court to direct the estate officer to decide the issue of the maintainability of the proceedings under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act, 1971, asking why they should not be evicted from the 7.58-acre premises known as Sujan Singh Park (north).

The petitioner contended that the estate officer has no jurisdiction to proceed in the matter because they are not an "unauthorised occupant" and the show-cause notice must be quashed.

The petitioner holds a registered "government grant" dated October 8, 1945 with respect to the land and the government's attempt to "re-enter" in 1960 after determination of the perpetual lease was declared "wrong and illegal" by a court in 2009, according to the petition.

The plea said its appeal is pending in the high court, termed the eviction notice illegal and said it has remained in possession for 83 years.



STUDENT EMPOWERMENT

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta launched the 'Saksham' programme at a government school in Shalimar Bagh to strengthen digital education, STEM learning, innovation and holistic student development across government schools in Delhi, Pune, Gurugram and Bengaluru with CSR support from Honeywell

As part of Child Safety Awareness Month, Delhi Police organised an interactive 'WE CARE' programme at Shri Ram Global School, Tikri Kalan, featuring self-defence demonstrations by the SPUWAC team, a performance by the Police Orchestra and an interaction with the SWAT team

—HEAVY RAIN INUNDATES DELHI; AQI CLEANEST SINCE 2023—
Water everywhere, way nowhere

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Relentless monsoon rain battered Delhi on Thursday, inundating roads, uprooting trees and triggering widespread traffic snarls. The downpour also helped the national capital record its cleanest air since September 2023, with parts of the city receiving over 160 mm of rainfall.

Authorities received 68 complaints of waterlogging during the day, while heavy rain disrupted traffic across several parts of the city. The spell also triggered a fresh political war of words between the ruling BJP and the opposition Aam Aadmi Party (AAP).

Water Minister Parvesh Verma criticising the previous AAP government, claimed that despite the city receiving over 100 mm of rain, traffic moved smoothly at the Minto Bridge underpass, where even large buses had routinely been stranded during downpours earlier.

According to officials, the Public Works Department (PWD) received 40 complaints of waterlogging, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) 16 and the New Delhi Municipal

CM inspected drainage arrangements in her Shalimar Bagh constituency, as government agencies remained on alert

Council (NDMC) 12.

The NDMC also received 26 complaints of power outages and reported five incidents of tree falls across its jurisdiction.

Waterlogging was reported from several areas, including Vikas Marg, parts of East Delhi, Sangam Vihar, the New Delhi railway station area, Munirka, Sadar Bazar, Alipur, Burari, Badarpur and Dwarka. In Alipur, several trucks and cars were partially submerged, disrupting traffic and affecting commuters.

Traffic was also disrupted at ITO, Rohtak Road, the Mehrauli-Badarpur (MB) Road, NH-48, Ring Road, Punjabi Bagh and Shadipur due to waterlogging and heavy congestion.

According to the Delhi Fire Service (DFS), two trees fell at separate locations on Raja Dhir Singh Marg in East of Kailash, while one tree each fell on Guru Ravidas Marg in the Kalkaji-Govindpuri area and Dhingra Marg. Another large tree fell on a parked car in Ranjeet Nagar.

The city's 24-hour average Air Quality Index (AQI) stood at 48 on Thursday, the cleanest air recorded in nearly two years and ten months. The last time Delhi's AQI was lower was on September 10, 2023, when it stood at 45.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), Safdarjung, the city's base weather station, recorded 72.6mm of rainfall in the 24 hours ending at 8.30 am on Thursday. Tukhmipur in north-east Delhi's Khajuri received the highest rainfall at 160 mm during this period, it said.

Mayur Vihar received 103 mm of rainfall, Delhi University 90 mm, Mehrauli 86 mm, Pusa and Lodhi Road AWS 83 mm each, Lodhi Road 80 mm, Ridge 78 mm and Chhatarpur 72 mm.

Palam and Narayana recorded 63 mm of rainfall each, Janakpuri 62 mm, Ayanagar 57 mm, Pragati Maidan 50 mm, Najafgarh 43 mm, Mungeshpur

41 mm, Jharoda Kalan 33 mm and Jafarpur 6 mm.

Between 8:30 am and 5:30 pm, Safdarjung recorded 32.4 mm of rainfall, while Lodhi Road received 33.2 mm. Ridge logged 25.6 mm, Palam recorded 1.8 mm and Ayanagar received 3.8 mm of rainfall, according to the IMD.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta inspected drainage arrangements in her Shalimar Bagh constituency, as government agencies remained on alert.

Officials said teams of the PWD, MCD and Delhi Jal Board (DJB) had been deployed across the city to prevent waterlogging and ensure prompt drainage of accumulated rainwater.

The ruling BJP claimed the city did not witness widespread waterlogging despite heavy rainfall over the past three days.

Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra said extensive desilting of drains and sewer lines had been carried out over the past one-and-a-half months under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta. He said 169 waterlogging points and 445 vulnerable locations had been identified, while 167 pump houses and 754 mobile pumps were installed before June 28.



Commuters make their way through a waterlogged road during rainfall, at Jangpura, on Thursday morning

Noida, Ghaziabad in DEEP WATER

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NOIDA/GHAZIABAD: Heavy rainfall disrupted normal life in Noida and adjoining Ghaziabad on Thursday, causing widespread waterlogging, traffic snarls and the collapse of a residential road that sent a parked car and a scooter plunging into a pit. Authorities also declared a holiday in government schools in Ghaziabad.

In one of the most serious rain-related incidents, a section of a road in Vasundhara Sector 13 in Ghaziabad caved in beside an under-construction basement after incessant rain, sending a parked car and a scooter into the pit. A nearby electricity pole also tilted into the crater. No one was injured, but both vehicles were extensively damaged.

Vehicle owner Ajay Agrawal said the vehicles were parked outside his house, where he lives with his brother Pushkar Singh, a retired superintendent engineer of the Awas Vikas Parishad.

He alleged that a builder had excavated nearly 20 feet for a basement without adequate safety arrangements and that the road suddenly gave way towards the excavation around 8 am due to continuous rain.

According to Agrawal, the builder later used a crane to retrieve the vehicles. He said he has lodged a complaint at the Indirapuram police station, seeking action against the builder, proper safety arrangements at the construction site and compensation for the damage caused to his vehicles.

In Noida, several areas, including Sectors 16, 33 and 12, witnessed severe waterlogging, with knee-deep water reported at places, making movement difficult for pedestrians and two-wheeler riders.

Several motorcycles and

Road caves in, car falls into pit as heavy rain inundates Noida and Ghaziabad

scooters stalled after water entered their exhausts, forcing riders to push their vehicles through flooded stretches. Some commuters crossed inundated roads by walking along roadside dividers.

Heavy traffic congestion was reported during the morning peak hours near the Botanical Garden area, where hundreds of cars, buses and two-wheelers moved at a crawl or remained stranded for long periods. A police officer said traffic was disrupted due to increased congestion caused by the rain but added that personnel remained deployed to regulate movement and ease traffic flow. In Sector 63, a boundary wall of a company collapsed due to the rain. No injuries were reported.

In Ghaziabad, the district administration declared a holiday in government schools because of the heavy rainfall.

Local residents blamed poor drainage for the situation.

Shalini Singh, executive chairperson of the NGO Noida Citizen Forum, said the rainfall had exposed the inadequacy of the Noida Authority's monsoon preparedness. "Officials should step out of their air-conditioned offices and see the actual condition on the ground. When a little rain brings the city to a standstill, it is not merely a natural disaster but an administrative failure," she said, demanding accountability, disclosure of drainage-related contracts and action against officials responsible for lapses.

Rain tests City readiness

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Heavy rainfall that lashed the national capital over the past 24 hours put Delhi's monsoon preparedness to its biggest test this season, prompting the government to activate round-the-clock monitoring and emergency response teams across the city. While waterlogging was reported from several areas, the Delhi government claimed that major roads and traditionally flood-prone underpasses remained largely functional due to extensive pre-monsoon preparations.

According to the India Meteorological Department (IMD), Delhi recorded 72.6 mm of rainfall in the 24 hours ending at 8.30 am on Thursday. Waterlogging was reported from Vikas Marg, parts of East Delhi, New Delhi Railway Station, Munirka, Sadar Bazar and Dwarka.

Officials said all government agencies were put on alert under the directions of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, with teams of the Public Works Department (PWD), Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and Delhi Jal Board (DJB) deployed across the city to respond to complaints.

PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh reviewed the city's preparedness from the department's 24x7 Monsoon Control Room, where he monitored live CCTV feeds, assessed field operations and directed officials to maintain maximum preparedness.

The department said it has identified 45 waterlogging-prone locations, including major underpasses, all of which are under continuous surveillance through 179 CCTV cameras linked to the central control room. To tackle water



KEY POINTS

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the past 48 hours through the control room and helpline network, with most cases attended to within 15 to 30 minutes, depending on rainfall intensity and site conditions.

Addressing the review meeting, Parvesh Sahib Singh said, "There was a time when Delhiites would worry every time it rained because waterlogging meant blocked roads, stranded vehicles and hours of inconvenience. We had assured the people that this situation would change through better planning and stronger infrastructure."

Referring to key underpasses, he added, "More than 100 mm of rainfall has been recorded in several parts of Delhi over the last 24 hours, yet locations like Minto Bridge, Zakhira, Dhaula Kuan and Moolchand... have continued to function with traffic moving smoothly. This has been possible because of months of preparation and the tireless efforts of our engineers, field staff and emergency teams."

The minister directed all officers to remain on high alert throughout the monsoon season and ensure close coordination among departments for quick response, smooth traffic movement and public convenience.

Seven-year-old boy drowns in waterlogged vacant plot in Samaypur Badli

NEW DELHI: A seven-year-old boy drowned in a waterlogged vacant plot in the Samaypur Badli area here on Thursday morning, police said.

The deceased — Rehan, a Class 3 student residing in Sanjaya Colony — had left home with his five-year-old brother around 8.30 am to attend nature's call when he drowned, police said. According to police, the plot had accumulated a large amount of rainwater following continuous showers in the last two days. The child waded to a deeper part of the waterlogged plot and drowned.

Rehan's mother said her younger son returned home while the elder one did not. When he failed to return even after a long time, the worried family began a search and also informed the police.

"My son had gone out in the morning to attend nature's call. When he did not come back for a long time, we informed our relatives and started searching for him," the mother told reporters, struggling to hold back tears. She said the family later found Rehan's bottle placed on the stone boundary of the waterlogged plot. "When we saw the bottle lying on the stone fence, we feared something was wrong. My brother-in-law and other family members searched the water. The plot was filled with rainwater, and my son was found inside a pit in the plot. If it were not filled with water, my son would have been alive today," the grieving mother said.

Gzb: Waterlogging claims young life

DIPIKA KIROLA

GHAZIABAD: A three-year-old girl drowned in rainwater accumulated outside her home in Ghaziabad's Vijay Nagar area on Thursday afternoon, said officials.

The victim, Pallavi, lived with her family in a rented house in Gali No. 16 of Sarvodaya Nagar. Her father, Sumit Kumar is a native of Farrukhabad district who works as a vegetable vendor. The family also includes his wife and their elder daughter.

According to police, the child stepped out of the house around 2 pm while the lane was heavily waterlogged after continuous rainfall. She allegedly slipped into the stagnant water and drowned. Family members and neighbours remained unaware until around 2.30 pm, when locals spotted her body floating. She was immediately taken to a nearby hospital, where doctors declared her dead.

The girl's death triggered outrage among residents, who blocked NH-9 and accused the municipal corporation of ignoring repeated complaints about choked sewers and overflowing drains. Protesters demanded that senior civic officials visit the area and ensure corrective measures before the child's last rites were performed.

Police, district administration officials and municipal corporation representatives reached the spot and held talks with the family and protesters.

Officials assured them of all possible assistance, while the administration also offered the victim's father a contractual job.



A waterlogged Gaur City underpass during heavy rainfall, at Noida, in Gautam Buddha Nagar district, on Thursday

Delhi building collapse toll hits 3

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The death toll in the building collapse in north-west Delhi's Rohini climbed to three, with two more bodies pulled out from the rubble during the rescue operation that went on through the night, police said on Thursday. An FIR has been registered in connection with the incident, in which one labourer was injured, police said. Earlier, officials had put the number of injured at five.

The details of the FIR were not known immediately.

The rescue operation was launched on Wednesday evening after the four-storey building that was under construction collapsed amid heavy rain.

In an official statement, Deputy Commissioner of Police (Rohini) Shashank Jaiswal said, "During the operation, one labourer, identified as Saddam alias Ravi (32), was pulled out alive from the debris and shifted for treatment."

He said three bodies were recovered during the rescue operation. The deceased were identified as Ram (42), a local tailor; Kafe alias Nurul (24), a labourer; and Ram Dua (62),

the father of the building owner. Ram was taken to the hospital, where he was declared brought dead. The other two bodies were pulled out from the debris during the prolonged search operation, the DCP said. The rescue operation is almost complete. Debris removal is underway to ensure that no one else is trapped, the statement said. An FIR has been registered in connection with the incident and the exact cause of the collapse is under investigation, Jaiswal said.

The building collapsed around 4.20 pm on Wednesday at property no. G-4/152 and

G-4/153 near an MCD school in Sector 16.

Police, DFS, National Disaster Response Force, MCD, Revenue Department and other agencies launched a massive rescue operation, deploying heavy machinery to clear the debris.

The MCD said on Wednesday that the collapsed structures had received sanctioned building plans under the SARAL Scheme, which allows property owners to get automatic clearance and building permits by submitting a self-verified undertaking through certified architects or engineers.

Govt renames Shahjahanabad Redevelopment Corporation

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi government has renamed the Shahjahanabad Redevelopment Corporation, set up for the conservation and redevelopment of Old Delhi, as the Indraprastha Virasat Punarvikas Nigam (IVPN), Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Thursday. Chairing the annual general meeting of the IVPN, Gupta directed officials to expedite the redevelopment of Chandni Chowk, improve parking facilities and build public toilets to enhance public convenience.

"Development of Old Delhi should not remain confined to physical infrastructure alone. Instead, heritage conservation, tourism promotion, economic activity, civic amenities, and environmental balance should all be

pursued through an integrated approach," Gupta said.

With this objective, the IVPN will undertake heritage conservation alongside modern urban development, she said. "The initiative will include conservation of historic buildings, modernisation of infrastructure, solid waste management, traffic management, expansion of tourism facilities and other related aspects," Gupta said in a statement. The chief minister directed officials to ensure that the market's design reflects its historical identity, traditional character, and cultural significance. "Keeping in view the movement of lakhs of people through the area every day, modern and functional public toilet blocks should be developed, and civic amenities should be further strengthened," she added.

CM FLAGS OFF CONSTRUCTION OF KEY UNDERGROUND METRO STRETCH

Delhi Metro's next big leap

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday launched the construction of the 12.377-km fully underground Inderlok-Indraprastha Metro corridor, describing the project as a major step towards strengthening the capital's public transport network. The work commenced with diaphragm wall construction at the upcoming Sarai Rohilla Metro Station, marking the beginning of one of the most significant extensions of the Delhi Metro's Magenta Line.

Addressing the event, Gupta said, "The Delhi Metro is not merely a mode of transport but the foundation of a developed Delhi." She added that the expansion would provide citizens with "safe, fast, convenient and environment-friendly public transport" while helping



reduce traffic congestion, pollution and fuel consumption. Stressing Centre-state cooperation, she said the Delhi government was working closely with the Union government and the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) to build world-class infrastructure.

The corridor will have 10 underground stations, Inderlok, Daya Basti, Sarai Rohilla, Ajmal Khan Park, Jhandewalan Temple, Nabi Karim,

New Delhi, Delhi Gate, Delhi Sachivalaya-IG Stadium and Indraprastha. Once completed, the Magenta Line will stretch nearly 89 km, becoming the longest corridor in the Delhi Metro network with the highest number of interchange and underground stations.

The new corridor will provide interchange with seven Metro lines, the Red and Green lines at Inderlok, Magenta Line at Nabi Karim, Yellow and

Airport Express lines at New Delhi, Violet Line at Delhi Gate and Blue Line at Indraprastha.

According to DMRC, the extension will significantly improve connectivity to key landmarks, including New Delhi and Sarai Rohilla railway stations, Delhi Sachivalaya, Arun Jaitley Stadium, Jhandewalan Temple, India Gate, Kartavya Path and the Central Vista area. The corridor will also operate as a driverless Metro line upon completion.

DMRC also said construction is progressing on other priority sections of the Magenta Line extension, with the Janakpuri West-Krishna Park Extension (1.8 km) and Deepali Chowk-Majlis Park (9.9 km) stretches already operational, while the remaining sections will be opened in phases. Construction on the Central Vista Metro corridor is also underway.

31K Oxytocin stored at room temp seized

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government's Drugs Control Department has seized over 31,000 Oxytocin injections from a pharmaceutical premises in the Patparganj Industrial area after officials allegedly found them stored at room temperature, violating mandatory cold chain norms, officials said on Thursday.

The action occurred in east Delhi during a special inspection conducted under the department's enforcement programme following directions from Delhi Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh.

According to the government, 31,700 Oxytocin injection IP 5 IU/ml vials were found stored at room temperature despite the product label specifying that the medicine must be stored between 2 and 8 degrees Celsius.

Officials said the stock had allegedly remained under such conditions since it was procured in May this year.

The Drugs Control Department said the storage did not comply with Rule 65(17) of the Drugs Rules, 1945.

Although a functional refrigerator was available at the premises, the department noted that no medicines requiring cold storage were found inside it.

Officials said considering Oxytocin's critical therapeutic use and the possibility of deterioration in its potency due to prolonged improper storage, the department seized the entire stock under the provisions of the Drugs and Cosmetics Act, 1940.

The department also collected details of supplies already made from the batch to facilitate stop-sale and recall directions, wherever required.

ENTIRE SPECTRUM OF BILATERAL TIES REVIEWED

India, Afghanistan hold key meet in Delhi

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India and Afghanistan on Thursday held a key meeting here during which the two sides reviewed the entire spectrum of bilateral relations, including cooperation in the fields of humanitarian assistance, development partnership, food security, healthcare, education, trade, visa and connectivity.

The fourth round of India-Afghanistan Joint Committee Meeting was co-chaired by M Anand Prakash, Joint Secretary (PAI), Ministry of External Affairs and Shuaib Baryalai, Director General, First Political Division, Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Afghanistan.

The PAI division in the



MEA Joint Secretary for the Pakistan, Afghanistan, and Iran division Anand Prakash with Afghanistan Ministry of Foreign Affairs Director of Consular Affairs Mohammad Shoaib Baryalai during the India-Afghanistan Joint Committee Meeting, in New Delhi. Other officials from both sides also seen in picture PFI

MEA refers to Pakistan, Afghanistan and Iran.

“The two sides reviewed the entire spectrum of bilateral relations, including

cooperation in the fields of humanitarian assistance, development partnership, food security, healthcare, capacity building, education,

sports, trade, visa and connectivity,” the MEA said in a statement.

The Indian side reiterated its continued commitment to

HIGHLIGHTS

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supporting the welfare and development needs of the Afghan people.

“The Afghan side appreciated India’s sustained support and cooperation across various sectors,” it said.

Both sides reaffirmed the

importance of maintaining regular consultations and agreed to remain in close contact.

The next round of the Joint Committee Meeting will be held at a mutually convenient time, the MEA said.

Union minister’s son...

Continued from Page 1

The case was registered on May 8 at Petbasheerabad police station after the mother of a 17-year-old girl alleged that Bageerath, who was in a relationship with her daughter, had sexually harassed her. Following the girl’s statement, additional provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the POCSO

Act were invoked. Bageerath also filed a counter-complaint, claiming the girl had introduced herself to him and invited him to family gatherings and religious trips. He alleged that she and her parents later pressured him to marry her, demanded money after he refused, and threatened to file false cases. Police also registered an FIR on his complaint. **MPOST**

Court cites childbirth...

Continued from Page 1

Further custody unnecessary. At the same time, the judge observed that the FIR and investigation attributed a clear role to Khan. According to the probe, she and co-accused allegedly tried to brainwash the victim, persuade her to change her religious beliefs, and claimed there were objectionable stories in Hinduism. Investigators alleged Khan gave the victim a burqa and religious literature, installed Islamic applications on her phone, taught her namaz at her home and showed her how to wear a hijab.

Defence lawyer Rahul Kasiwal

argued that Khan, a former TCS associate dismissed in April 2026, was innocent and had been falsely implicated. Prosecutors Vijay Gaikwad, along with lawyers Milind Kurkute and Nitin Pandit for one of the victims, opposed bail, alleging evidence pointed to sexual exploitation and attempts at religious conversion.

The case is among nine being investigated by a Nashik police SIT into alleged exploitation, forced conversion attempts, molestation and harassment of women employees. TCS has said it follows a zero tolerance policy against harassment and has suspended employees allegedly involved. **MPOST**

From Page 1 Modi, Albanese

We have now decided to accelerate work on the Comprehensive Economic Cooperation,” Modi said in a post on X.

A major outcome of the summit was the completion of administrative arrangements under the India-Australia Civil Nuclear Agreement, clearing the way for commercial uranium exports from Australia to India for its civilian nuclear energy programme. The agreement comes after more than two years of negotiations and builds on the landmark civil nuclear cooperation pact signed by the two countries in 2014.

“Today, we have signed an important agreement in the field of nuclear energy. This will open the way for uranium supplies from Australia to India and give new impetus to our clean energy objectives,” Modi said.

Albanese said the arrangement would help expand non-fossil fuel power generation while creating an additional export market for Australia’s uranium industry.

The two leaders also announced a Joint Declaration on Defence and Security Cooperation, replacing the 2009 security declaration and broadening collaboration in defence interoperability, maritime security, cyber security, counter-terrorism, defence industry partnerships, humanitarian assistance and disaster relief. Complementing the declaration, India and Australia launched a Maritime Security Collaboration Roadmap aimed at strengthening information sharing, operational coordination and capability development across the Indo-Pacific. The roadmap also includes closer cooperation in shipbuilding, ship repair and maintenance while encouraging greater interoperability between the armed forces and expanding aircraft deployments from each other’s territories. An agreement between the Indian Coast Guard and Australia’s Maritime Border Command will deepen cooperation in maritime law enforcement, maritime domain awareness and border protection.

The defence initiatives came against the backdrop of rising regional concerns after China’s recent test of a submarine-launched long-range ballistic missile. Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri said Albanese had raised the issue during the discussions, with both sides agreeing on the need for peace, security and stability in the Indo-Pacific.

Calling the Indo-Pacific more than a geographical region, Modi said it represented “the shared aspirations of like-minded democracies like India and Australia.”

The summit also launched the Australia-India Partnership for Cyber, Critical Technologies and Supply Chains (PACTS), expanding cooperation in cyber security, critical technologies and resilient supply chains. Modi said the two countries would also work together on a critical minerals corridor to support strategic security and the clean energy transition.

The leaders renewed their commitment to strengthen energy security through a joint statement covering stable supplies of coal, diesel, natural gas and other fuels amid global geopolitical uncertainty.

Trade and investment featured prominently in the discussions. Modi said both countries would move quickly to conclude a balanced and mutually beneficial CECA while also advancing negotiations on a bilateral investment treaty.

Beyond strategic cooperation, the summit produced several initiatives in education, skills and cultural exchange. Victoria University received approval to establish its campus in

Gurugram, while Flinders University will move forward with plans to open a campus in Bengaluru, expanding Australia’s educational presence in India.

The two sides also signed an agreement between India’s Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship and Western Australia’s Technical and Further Education system to establish a Centre of Excellence in Mining and Mining Equipment, Technology and Services at the National Skill Training Institute in Bhubaneswar.

A separate Letter of Intent between India’s National Council for Vocational Education and Training and the Australian Skills Quality Authority will strengthen quality assurance in technical and vocational education through staff exchanges and joint workshops.

Other agreements included operationalising a Rooftop Solar Training Academy that will train around 2,000 women and young people as solar technicians, supporting India’s PM Surya Ghar Yojana. A memorandum between Geoscience Australia and the Geological Survey of India will expand collaboration in mineral exploration, scientific research and skill development. Another agreement under the Australia-Canada-India Technology and Innovation Partnership will promote trilateral cooperation in emerging technologies.

Australia also invited an Indian military instructor to serve at the Australian Defence College during 2028-29, reflecting closer defence engagement between the two countries. In a symbolic gesture, Australia returned three Indian antiquities dating to the 11th and 12th centuries, including a Nandi sculpture, a trident associated with Kali and a six-headed Skanda idol.

The two leaders also reaffirmed cooperation against terrorism and support for dialogue to resolve global conflicts. Misri said they exchanged views on regional issues, backed the Quad’s role in addressing challenges such as maritime security, cyber security, humanitarian assistance and critical technologies, and discussed expanding cooperation in space, including Australian support for India’s Gaganyaan human spaceflight programme.

Describing India as a “top-tier security partner”, Albanese said, “Australia’s relationship with India has never been more consequential than it is today. Our partnership has never been stronger.”

US, Iran

“US Central Command forces have started conducting additional strikes against Iran to further degrade their ability to threaten freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz,” CENTCOM said on X, adding that the United States was holding Iran accountable for what it called “recent unjustified aggression against commercial shipping and civilian crews”.

Fresh strikes hit the southeastern port city of Chabahar, marking the first attack there since April. Iranian state media reported widespread power outages as explosions rocked the strategic port. Residents said multiple blasts were heard while emergency crews rushed to damaged locations.

According to US officials, the operation targeted maritime infrastructure and military facilities linked to Iran’s capability to disrupt commercial shipping while avoiding civilian port facilities and major energy infrastructure.

Iranian state media also reported explosions in Bushehr, home to Iran’s only nuclear power plant, along with other southern cities. Ehsan Jahanian, a local official quoted by the state-run IRNA news agency, accused the US of striking near the Bushehr

nuclear facility around noon, hours after CENTCOM had announced the completion of its operations. The US military did not immediately comment. Although previous strikes had occurred near the Russian-managed nuclear plant during the conflict, no damage to the facility has been reported.

For the first time since April, US strikes also appeared to target Iranian bridges. State media reported an attack on a railway bridge in Golestan province, while Iran’s Revolutionary Guard said two bridges on the route to Mashhad were hit as preparations continued for the burial of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

Iran’s Health Ministry said two days of US airstrikes had killed at least 14 people and wounded 78 others, with most of the casualties reported among members of the armed forces. State media said three people were killed in Khuzestan province on Thursday, while an airport firefighter died in a strike in Iranshahr. Those deaths followed the reported killing of at least nine Iranian military personnel in Wednesday’s attacks.

The latest escalation followed Tuesday’s attack on three cargo ships in the Strait of Hormuz, which Washington blamed on Iran.

After leaving a NATO summit in Turkey, Trump posted videos that he said showed explosions in Iran and warned Tehran against further attacks on shipping. “This is in retribution for yesterday’s bombing of ships by Iran. If it happens again, it will get much worse!” Trump wrote.

Speaking later aboard Air Force One, Trump said the United States had inflicted much greater damage than Iran. “We just hit them very hard, and I say we hit them 20 to 1,” he said, adding, “Every time they hit us, we’re going to hit them 20.”

Asked whether the two countries were heading toward another full-scale conflict, Trump replied, “I don’t know, but we would win it very quickly.”

He also said the latest fighting was unlikely to become “long-term” military action, adding, “Anything that happens is going to happen very fast.”

Trump renewed earlier threats to target Iran’s civilian infrastructure, including power and desalination facilities, and suggested seizing Kharg Island, through which about 90 per cent of Iran’s oil exports pass.

Iranian leaders rejected Trump’s remarks. Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf wrote on X, “America still hasn’t learned that bullying and breaking promises are no longer cost-free. Let me put it plainly: If you strike, you’ll get hit.”

Deputy Foreign Minister Kazem Gharibabadi said Trump’s comments were “not a sign of power but an admission of the failure” of US policy toward Iran. Negotiations aimed at reaching a permanent agreement are expected to begin after Khamenei’s funeral concludes. The talks are expected to address reopening the Strait of Hormuz and the future of Iran’s disputed nuclear programme, but the latest military exchanges have cast fresh uncertainty over those efforts.

Kashmir schools

laws, harms national interest, or conflicts with educational values and established norms. The circular also states that all reading material must comply with the age-appropriate guidelines laid down under the National Education Policy 2020.

The order covers all educational institutions under the Directorate, including 10,787 government schools and 2,386 recognised private schools in the Kashmir division. Heads of institutions have also been instructed to certify that no objectionable material remains on their campuses after the screening. If any objectionable

content is found, school heads must prepare a detailed report listing the book’s title, author, publisher, year of publication and the number of copies available. The report, along with an abstract of the content identified, must be submitted to the concerned Chief Education Officer (CEO) or Zonal Education Officer (ZEO) within seven days of the July 6 circular.

The ZEOs have been asked to scrutinise and consolidate reports from schools and coaching centres before submitting them to the respective CEOs by July 15. The CEOs will then forward the final reports to the Directorate of School Education Kashmir by July 17. The circular states that CEOs will personally monitor the certification process, and any failure to comply with the directions could invite disciplinary action.

The directive comes days after the BJP raised objections over books allegedly glorifying separatist leaders that had been procured for government schools. It also follows the Jammu and Kashmir Home Department’s decision in August 2025 to ban the publication of 25 books on Kashmir, including works by Arundhati Roy and A G Noorani, on the grounds that they promoted secessionism.

Earlier this month, the government withdrew two books, Personalities and Legends of J&K by Hilal Ahmed and Santosh Meena, and Great Personalities of Jammu and Kashmir by Dr Sushant Giri, from school libraries after describing their content on separatism as highly inappropriate. The counter-intelligence wing of the J&K Police later searched the Jammu premises of the publisher of one of the books after registering a case under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. Education Minister Sakina Itoo had called the episode “unfortunate” and a “deliberate conspiracy”, saying strict action would be taken against those responsible for supplying such books to schools.

The order has drawn criticism from opposition leaders and some members of the ruling National Conference. MP Aga Syed Ruhullah Mehdi said reports of books on Kashmir’s history and identity being removed from educational institutions were “deeply troubling”. “Libraries exist to preserve knowledge, not curate political narratives. Erasing books doesn’t erase history; it only impoverishes scholarship,” he said, adding that academic freedom and engagement with history should not become “casualties of ideological control”. Peoples Democratic Party leader Waheed Para described the move as an attempt to “rewrite our collective memory”, saying it would limit future generations’ ability to question, think critically and understand their past.

Monsoon

Siang, Tirap, Changlang, Papum Pare and Upper Subansiri, damaging houses, roads and crops. An inter-ministerial team from the Ministry of Home Affairs visited East Siang and Lower Siang districts to assess flood damage and the need for additional central assistance. Rainfall is expected to ease from Friday, with an orange alert remaining for Papum Pare, Lower Dibang Valley and Tirap.

In Himachal Pradesh, a landslide near Maling Nallah in Kinnaur damaged three houses, a cowshed and orchards, while a 100-foot iron bridge was submerged by rising river water, cutting off access to Lippla village. Heavy rain continued in parts of the state, and the Shimla Meteorological Centre issued a yellow alert until July 15. Uttarakhand remained on high alert after continuous rainfall triggered landslides and raised river levels. Traffic was disrupted on 107 routes, including nine state highways. The IMD issued a red alert for seven districts, including Dehradun, while

schools from Classes 1 to 12 remained closed in four districts.

Heavy rain also affected Rajasthan, Haryana and Punjab. The IMD forecast extremely heavy rainfall in isolated parts of Kota and Bharatpur divisions. In Gurugram, part of the balcony of a luxury apartment complex collapsed, though no one was injured. Waterlogging and traffic snarls were also reported across Noida, Ghaziabad, Ghazipur and Faridabad. Ghaziabad declared a holiday in government schools, while a road caved in at Vasundhara, pulling a parked car and scooter into a pit without causing injuries.

The IMD said the southwest monsoon has now covered the entire country after advancing into the remaining parts of Rajasthan, Haryana and Punjab. India has received 101.9 mm of rainfall in the first nine days of July against the normal 73.8 mm. In Kerala, the IMD issued an orange alert for Malappuram, Kozhikode and Wayanad and a yellow alert for six other districts. In Wayanad, the landslide death toll rose to six after three more bodies were recovered, while search operations continued for two people still missing.

Hours after joining BJP

He added: “Their role in the Rajya Sabha, their political experience and their contribution to public life are well known. There is no need to introduce them afresh. Their decision proves that, in the changed political situation of West Bengal, people’s confidence in the leadership of the BJP is becoming increasingly stronger. After years of neglect, deprivation, apathy and oppression, the people of West Bengal have voted for change.”

Meanwhile, the Election Commission has announced that voting for the three Rajya Sabha bypolls will be held on July 24, with counting scheduled for the same evening. The resignations of the three leaders created vacancies in the Rajya Sabha, prompting the poll body to announce bypolls. BJP is eyeing to win all three seats after the party won the Bengal Assembly polls.

The Opposition’s combined numbers would have been sufficient to secure one of the three Rajya Sabha seats. However, the situation changed dramatically after the Trinamool split into rival factions led by former chief minister and party supremo Mamata Banerjee and Leader of Opposition Ritabrata Banerjee. According to current estimates, around 65 MLAs are aligned with the Ritabrata Banerjee faction, while roughly 15 legislators continue to support the Mamata Banerjee camp.

Reacting to the development, TMC MLA Kunal Ghosh, who aligns with the Mamata Banerjee faction of TMC, said the party had given Ray political opportunities that he did not receive before joining the TMC.

“Everyone knows that Sukhendu Sekhar, who is a senior leader, prior to 2011, never became MP or MLA. Respecting him, Mamata Banerjee sent him to the Rajya Sabha. Today, he joined the BJP. They did not leave when Mamata Banerjee was the CM. The public is seeing everything,” Ghosh said.

Interestingly, all three leaders had been vocal critics of the BJP until recently, campaigning aggressively against the party during the Assembly elections. Dev, in particular, had frequently targeted the BJP and had even alleged that BJP workers were behind attacks on her convoy during the campaign.

In a parallel political development, Berhampore MP Yusuf Pathan, who recently joined the National Citizens Party of India (NCPI), met Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari at Nabanna on Thursday.

Another Trinamool MP, Shatabdi Roy, is also believed to be weighing her political options, fuelling speculation over more possible defections from the party. ebel group also went to Nabanna on Thursday.

WhatsApp

After seeking additional time to respond, WhatsApp assured the government it would not roll out the feature in India until discussions concluded. There was no official statement from WhatsApp on the submission made to the ministry on Thursday. **MPOST**

BSNL announces

challenging environments and is suitable for defence, maritime, disaster response, mining, remote operations and adventure travel.

The telecom company asked interested users to contact their nearest BSNL office for more details and also shared a mobile number. However, the number did not respond when contacted. A verified X user also commented on the post, saying, “As Always. No one is responding to the above Given Number.” An email query sent to BSNL did not receive an immediate response.

BSNL has been offering voice call and SMS services through its Global Satellite Phone Service (GSPS) to the general public and private enterprises since January 1, 2018, according to an official statement issued in February.

The statement said the Department of Telecommunications had issued guidelines on June 12, 2017, requiring BSNL to complete the same customer verification process used for mobile connections. Subscribers are also required to provide details about the place, duration and purpose of satellite phone usage. It added that GSPS communications are encrypted.

BSNL’s postpaid plans for government and commercial users are priced at Rs 3,500, Rs 5,835 and Rs 11,670 per month, with 16, 30 and 60 minutes of free talk time or SMS, respectively. For prepaid services, government entities pay Rs 3,500 per month with 20 free minutes or Rs 38,500 annually with 240 free minutes. Commercial entities can opt for Rs 5,835 per month with 30 free minutes or Rs 64,185 annually with 360 free minutes. Beyond the free quota, government users are charged Rs 18 per minute or SMS, while commercial users pay Rs 25. Top-up vouchers are available in denominations ranging from Rs 200 to Rs 10,000.

Fall admissions

on Form I-20. The clarification comes as students seeking admission to US universities for the fall semester have raised concerns over the availability of visa interview appointments at US missions in India.

The authorities said the F-1 visa is meant for students pursuing academic studies at accredited institutions in the US. It also applies to students enrolled in academic programmes involving more than 18 hours of study per week. Those pursuing vocational or other non-academic courses must apply for an M-1 visa. Students were also advised to contact the EducationUSA advising network, the US Department of State’s official higher education advisory service. EducationUSA operates centres in Chennai, Delhi, Hyderabad, Kolkata and Mumbai, where more than 30 advisers assist students with university applications and the visa process.

The authorities also noted that US law does not allow foreign students on F-1 visas to enrol in publicly funded primary schools or publicly funded

adult education programmes. They may study at publicly funded secondary schools for up to one year only after paying the full, unsubsidised cost of education.

Explaining the documentation required for a visa application, officials said applicants must submit a completed DS-160 form, a passport valid for at least six months beyond their intended stay, a recent photograph, the original Form I-20 issued by their institution and proof of SEVIS fee payment. Married applicants travelling with the principal visa holder must also provide a marriage certificate. The authorities said eligible F-1 students may apply for Optional Practical Training (OPT), which allows them to gain practical work experience related to their field of study for up to 12 months after graduation. Applicants for OPT must present proof of approval from the US Citizenship and Immigration Services (USCIS). Officials also said students who remain outside the US for more than five months during a break in their studies could lose their student visa status unless the absence is directly related to their academic programme. In such cases, they may need to apply for a new F-1 or M-1 visa before returning to resume their studies.

While the US authorities clarified the student visa process and eligibility requirements, they did not indicate whether additional interview appointments would be made available, leaving many prospective students awaiting further updates.

Probe finds

Police said further recoveries of cash and jewellery are expected based on information provided by the accused. According to investigators, prime accused Anukalp Mishra told police that he and co-accused Avinash Shukla invested part of the stolen money in the stock market and also lent money to people on interest. Police sources said the accused allegedly transferred money to relatives and acquaintances before having it sent back to their own accounts to disguise its origin.

Searches have continued at the residences of the accused. On Thursday morning, police took Anukalp Mishra to his house, searched the premises for about 20 minutes and questioned his family members. Similar searches were conducted at the homes of Lavkush Mishra and Karunesh Pandey on Wednesday. During these operations, police recovered bundles of cash, gold jewellery, including earrings and lockets, and a car. Authorities have not disclosed the amount of cash seized or from which residence the recoveries were made.

Police also recovered documents relating to the purchase of one acre of land in Anukalp Mishra’s name. The papers show the land was bought for about Rs 6.7 lakh, although investigators believe its current market value is much higher. The source of funds used for the purchase, along with the acquisition of a car, is under scrutiny. Investigators also alleged that fake donation receipts were printed and used to collect money from devotees, with the cash allegedly kept instead of being deposited. During the probe, police revisited an orchard on the 14 Kosi Parikrama route where the accused allegedly divided the stolen money and verified their statements against earlier disclosures.

The controversy surfaced in early June after alleged irregularities were found in the counting of temple donations. The Uttar Pradesh government formed a Special Investigation Team on the recommendation of the temple trust. After finding prima facie evidence of embezzlement, the SIT led to the registration of an FIR and the arrest of eight people associated with donation counting.

SAYS INDIA WORKING TO BECOME DEVELOPED NATION

PM Modi pitches ‘Grow More, Achieve More’ vision in Melbourne

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MELBOURNE: India, driven by the vision of “Grow More, Achieve More”, is working towards the goal of becoming a developed nation, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Thursday, underscoring that the foundation of the country’s big dreams and great aspirations is its people.

Speaking at an Indian diaspora event, ‘Melbourne meets Modi’, also attended by Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese, PM Modi said he was delighted that the partnership between the two countries in the areas of education, skills and innovation is deepening and strengthening.

“India of the 21st century is working towards the goal of becoming a developed nation. When one dream is realised, a new one is born. This is an India that believes in ‘Grow



PM Narendra Modi and Australian PM Anthony Albanese during an event in Melbourne

More, Achieve More”, Modi said, amid cheers from the audience.

“We are a nation of 1.4 billion people brimming with aspirations; we are impatient and eager. We are the world’s fastest-growing economy, yet we aim to become one of the

top three economies in the world as quickly as possible. Because our driving force is ‘Grow More, Achieve More”, he added.

“The foundation of India’s big dreams and great aspirations is its people... We, the People,” he said, adding that

Highlights

» PM Modi said he was delighted that the partnership between the two countries in the areas of education, skills and innovation is deepening and strengthening

» “India of the 21st century is working towards the goal of becoming a developed nation. When one dream is realised, a new one is born. This is an India that believes in ‘Grow More, Achieve More”, Modi said.

the world’s second-largest 5G market. Moreover, India is rapidly working on ‘Made in India’ 6G technology as well. This is because Indians believe in the mantra: “Grow More, Achieve More”, he said.

“India does not want to stop here...a new manufacturing ecosystem -- spanning everything from chips to ships -- is being developed in India today,” he added.

He underlined that India’s approach was not just to focus on its own progress, but to walk hand in hand with its friends and partners.

Dwelling upon ‘Operation Sindoor’, PM Modi said the world has witnessed the capability and credibility of India’s defence platform. “You must have seen the demo during ‘Operation Sindoor’. Explosions were taking place at the terrorists’ hideouts, and the echo was reverberating across the world,” he said.

the government’s policies are centred on citizens’ welfare.

Modi talked about the rapid progress taking place in India, based on sustained high growth, policy reforms, digital revolution and next-generation infrastructure development.

“Today, India has become

Punjab Cong truce? Channi camp to meet Baghel

CHANDIGARH: In a climb-down amid the Punjab Congress leadership buzz, senior leaders considered close to former chief minister Charanjit Singh Channi on Thursday relented and decided to meet AICC general secretary in-charge Bhupesh Baghel, a day after he ruled out any change in the state party leadership.

Jalandhar Cantt MLA Pargat Singh said, “We will meet Baghel and present our views”. The development comes days after Baghel, also the former chief minister of Chhattisgarh, began his five-day visit to Punjab to prepare the party for the Punjab polls due early next year.

Sources said the meeting is likely to take place on Friday, the concluding day of Baghel’s visit.

Former chief minister and



The Punjab Congress has been battling an internal rift of late

Jalandhar MP Channi, who is said to be unhappy over not being appointed the state president, along with leaders considered close to him, including Pargat Singh, Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, Rana Gurjit and Bharat Bhushan Ashu are yet to meet Baghel. The AICC general secretary has held a series of interactions with party leaders and office-bearers during his visit.

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Thursday stepped up its attack on the government over the “sudden sacking” of four close aides of Environment Minister Bhupendra Yadav, alleging that there has been a “gigantic scandal” that has led to the dismissals.

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said from June 2025 onwards, determined efforts have been made by the Union Ministry of Environment, Forests, and Climate Change and the Rajasthan government to redraw the critical tiger habitat boundary at Sariska. This will enable over 50 mining companies, which have been closed down, to resume operations, he said.

“Then on September 20 2025, the Forest Survey of India in a communication to the Ministry of Environment, Forests and Climate Change had recommended strongly against the redefinition of

Cong questions PM’s silence on Ram temple ‘embezzlement’

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Thursday questioned Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s silence over the issue of “embezzlement” of Ram temple donations and alleged that attempts are being made to save the “big fish” and take action against small employees. In a post on X, Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh claimed that several irregularities relating to land purchase and construction of the temple have also come to light. “After the theft of offerings at the Ram temple in Ayodhya came to light, several major irregularities related to land purchase and construction have also surfaced. Despite all this, PM Modi remains silent and the entire BJP-RSS apparatus is attempting to protect the big fish by taking action against a few small employees,” Ramesh said on X.

These developments bear the Aravalli Hills that would open up the range to mining and real estate development. The Supreme Court-mandated Central Empowered Committee and the Supreme Court’s Amicus Curiae had also supported the FSI. Yet the Ministry advocated the redefinition,” he said on X.

These developments bear

recall now in light of the sudden sacking of four close aides of the Union Minister of Environment, Forests and Climate Change, Ramesh said. “This shows a complete collapse of due diligence and accountability at the very top. Undoubtedly there has been a gigantic scandal that has led to these dismissals,” he added.

‘Resignations won’t end Ram Temple case’: Akhilesh seeks judicial probe

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav on Wednesday intensified his attack on the BJP and the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust over the alleged Ram Temple donation theft, demanding that the trust be dissolved and the entire matter investigated through a judicial inquiry.

In a post on X, Yadav said merely accepting resignations would not be enough to close the controversy. He said the entire trust should be dissolved and subjected to an independent judicial probe.

Questioning the police investigation, the SP chief said the manner in which the



accused were allegedly welcomed by police had raised several questions. He argued that if a driver could be held responsible in a case, the owner should also be held accountable.

Yadav also questioned the investigation process, asking how a person’s name, which did not figure in the interim report, appeared in the final report. He further claimed that

the individual on whom most of the blame had been placed did not appear to be the principal offender according to the findings of the report.

He said action against lower-level employees alone would not ensure justice and that accountability should also be fixed on those who had entrusted them with responsibility. He demanded a judicial investigation into all land transactions and other decisions approved under the signatures of those who have resigned from the trust, saying resignation should not become a route to escape responsibility.

The former UP CM also called for close monitoring of the future activities and foreign travel of those found guilty.

ED raids ex-UP MLA in Rs 23 cr DA case

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Directorate of Enforcement (ED) has conducted searches at 11 different places in Uttar Pradesh in connection with the disproportionate assets and money laundering case involving former Garauttha MLA Deep Narayan Singh Yadav and his associates. The searches by the ED’s Allahabad Sub-Zonal Office commenced on Wednesday, under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002, at Jhansi, Lucknow and other places in the state.

The case is linked to the First Information Report (FIR) registered by the Uttar Pradesh Vigilance Establishment. It alleged that Yadav had acquired assets worth Rs 23.02 crore, which were disproportionate to his known sources of income, during the relevant time frame. “Yadav is also accused of having more than 60 criminal cases registered against him in the districts of Jhansi and other parts of Uttar Pradesh. These cases pertain to crimes like dacoity, attempt to murder, extortion, attempt to commit culpable homicide, criminal breach of trust, cheating, and forgery under the Indian Penal Code. Some of these are cognizable offenses under PMLA,” the ED said. The ED alleged that Yadav had generated substantial proceeds of crime through the commission of crimes and by misusing his position as a Member of the Legislative Assembly. It added that he has created multiple companies, including shell companies to cover up the illegal gains. Through a network of companies, Yadav’s proceeds were integrated to show them as business proceeds through layers of trading. It also alleged that Yadav has purchased movable and immovable properties by utilizing proceeds of crime in the names of his associates and distant relatives.

Champat Rai backs Trust reforms, claims Trust treasurer Govind Giri

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust treasurer Swami Govind Dev Giri has said former general secretary Champat Rai is in good health, has no resentment over recent developments and continues to fully support the trust’s efforts to strengthen transparency and improve its administrative systems.

Speaking before leaving Ayodhya after meeting Champat Rai, Govind Dev Giri said they discussed his health, the functioning of the trust, arrangements at the Ram Temple and recent developments. He said Champat Rai stands firmly behind the decisions and

‘Rai stands firmly behind the decisions and reforms being implemented’

reforms being implemented by the trust. Describing Champat Rai as a disciplined organisation worker who has devoted his life to the service of the nation, the treasurer said every step being taken to make the trust’s functioning stronger and more transparent has his complete cooperation and support.

The statement is being seen as significant amid speculation over Champat Rai’s position following recent controversies

surrounding the trust.

Meanwhile, the investigation into the Ram Temple donation theft case has revealed fresh details during the custodial interrogation of the three accused.

According to the police, Anukalp Mishra, Lavkush Mishra and Karunesh Pandey allegedly diverted the stolen money through the bank accounts of relatives and close acquaintances to conceal its origin. Investigators said the accused would hand over cash to these individuals, who would then transfer the equivalent amount back to the accused through multiple bank transactions, making it difficult to trace the source of the funds.

AGMUT rejig sees 61 IAS, IPS officers shifted

21 IAS, 40 IPS officers transferred; Shahid Choudhary moved from J&K to Arunachal

NEW DELHI: In a major administrative reshuffle, the Ministry of Home Affairs on Thursday transferred with immediate effect 21 IAS and 40 IPS officers of the Arunachal Pradesh, Goa, Mizoram, and Union Territories (AGMUT) cadre.

Among the prominent changes, 2009-batch IAS officer Shahid Iqbal Choudhary has been transferred from Jammu and Kashmir to Arunachal Pradesh, while 2017-batch IPS officer Tanushree has been shifted from J&K to Delhi.

The transfer order, issued with the approval of the competent authority, also posted IAS officer Saugat Biswas (2006 batch) from Arunachal Pradesh to J&K, while IAS Swati Sheemar (2023 batch) was transferred from J&K to Delhi. IAS officer Mamta Yadav (2021 batch) has been moved from Delhi to J&K.

Among IPS officers, Deepika (2018 batch) has been transferred from J&K to Puducherry, Gaurav Sikarwar (2019 batch) from J&K to Goa, Vishnu Kumar (2019 batch) from Delhi to J&K,

Key Points

- » Among the prominent changes, 2009-batch IAS officer Shahid Iqbal Choudhary has been transferred from Jammu and Kashmir to Arunachal Pradesh, while 2017-batch IPS officer Tanushree has been shifted from J&K to Delhi
- » The reshuffle also brought a significant number of AGMUT (Arunachal Pradesh-Goa-Mizoram and Union Territories) cadre officers to the national capital
- » The order has also posted IPS officers

Pukhraj Kamal (2018) and Lokeshwaran R (2018) from Mizoram, Gaurav Tyagi (2019) from Mizoram, Angad Mehta (2020) from Arunachal Pradesh, Utarksha (2021) from Lakshadweep and R Subash from Puducherry to Delhi

» Among the IAS officers posted to Delhi are Vivek Pandey (2003) from Arunachal Pradesh, Garima Gupta (2004) from Mizoram, Pawan Kumar Sain (2005) from Arunachal Pradesh, Amjad Tak (2005) from Arunachal Pradesh

K M Priyanka (2021 batch) from Chandigarh to J&K, Anand Kumar Mishra from Delhi to J&K, and Satish Kumar from Delhi to J&K.

The reshuffle also brought a significant number of AGMUT (Arunachal Pradesh-Goa-Mizoram and Union Territories) cadre offi-

cers to the national capital.

Among the IAS officers posted to Delhi are Vivek Pandey (2003) from Arunachal Pradesh, Garima Gupta (2004) from Mizoram, Pawan Kumar Sain (2005) from Arunachal Pradesh, Amjad Tak (2005) from Arunachal Pradesh, Ajay Kumar Gupta

(2010) from Dadra and Nagar Haveli and Daman and Diu (DNH&DD), Awanish Kumar (2014) from Lakshadweep and Shweta Nagarkoti (2020) from Arunachal Pradesh.

Among the IPS officers transferred to Delhi are Vivek Kishore (1999) from Arunachal Pradesh, Sindhu Pillai A (2001) from Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Chinmoy Biswal (2008) from Arunachal Pradesh, A Koan (2009) and Jiten-dra Kumar Meena (2012) from Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Varsha Sharma (2010) from Goa, Anil Kumar Lal (2013) from Puducherry, Manjeet (2015) and Geetanjali Khandelwal (2015) from Chandigarh and Satyawan Gautam (2016) from Arunachal Pradesh.

The order has also posted IPS officers Pukhraj Kamal (2018) and Lokeshwaran R (2018) from Mizoram, Gaurav Tyagi (2019) from Mizoram, Angad Mehta (2020) from Arunachal Pradesh, Utarksha (2021) from Lakshadweep and R Subash from Puducherry to Delhi.

remarks have exposed the deep divisions within the opposition alliance, alleging that it has no mission, vision or unity.

“MVA does not stand for Maha Vikas Aghadi, it stands for Maha Vibhajan Aghadi. Sanjay Raut has now attacked Sharad Pawarji simply because he met Eknath Shinde. This shows that they have neither a mission nor a vision -- only confusion and division,” Poonawalla said in a video statement.

He claimed that the Shiv Sena (UBT) is unable to keep its own party united, while it repeatedly targets its allies.

“First of all, Uddhav Sena is unable to keep itself united, yet

it keeps attacking the Congress and, at times, Sharad Pawar and the NCP. Where is their unity? Are they united by any mission or vision? No, they are completely divided on issues such as Savarkar, Article 370 and Hindutva. They do not see eye to eye on anything,” he said.

Poonawalla claimed that the only factor holding the opposition alliance together is its opposition to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the BJP. “The only thing that brings them together is political convenience to oppose Prime Minister Modi and the BJP. But they fail miserably every time. This is their true face,” he said.

Nadda slams Cong over ‘North-South divide’ narrative

HYDERABAD: Union Health Minister J P Nadda on Thursday hit out at the Congress for ‘trying to create the ‘North-South divide’ narrative on devolution of tax and funds to southern states.

Speaking at an event organised by Forum for Nationalist Thinkers here, he also alleged that the Congress government in Telangana has turned out to be an ATM to the party’s central leadership.

Referring to Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy’s accusations against the Centre for not allocating funds to the state, Nadda said: “Revanth Reddy’s mathematics is very weak. He always keeps on saying that the Centre has not given anything. These Congress people say the same complaint. They do the same thing in Himachal Pradesh (where Congress government is in power) also.” The union minister said under tax devolution, Rs 2.74 lakh crore has been given to Telangana, adding that whatever is the state’s share has been given to it.

Nation Briefs

SECURE CAUVERY WATER FROM KARNATAKA, AIADMK CHIEF TELLS TN GOVT

CHENNAI: AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami on Thursday urged the ruling TVK to immediately secure Tamil Nadu’s share of Cauvery water due for June and July, warning the state government against remaining idle while Karnataka “plays with the lives of TN people.” Launching a scathing attack on neighbouring Karnataka over the Cauvery water issue, the former chief minister said in a strongly worded statement that Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay should issue a firm political warning to the Congress government. “Is CM Vijay ready to warn the Karnataka Congress government that if Karnataka does not immediately release Cauvery water, then the Congress minister will be dropped from the Tamil Nadu Cabinet,” the AIADMK chief asked.

PARLIAMENT PANEL ON HEALTH TO DISCUSS CONDUCT OF NEET ON JULY 16

NEW DELHI: A parliamentary panel will next week discuss the functional proficiency of regulatory institutions under the Ministry of Health over the conduct of the NEET medical entrance examination. The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Health and Family Welfare headed by Samajwadi Party’s Ram Gopal Yadav will in its meeting on July 16 discuss the issue in detail. The NEET exam row has already been discussed by two other parliamentary panels, which had summoned top officials of the Health, and Higher Education ministries.

AT DELHI MEET, BOTH SIDES SEEK ACTION AGAINST TERRORISTS

India, Russia condemn Pahalgam terror attack

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India and Russia have jointly condemned terrorism in all its forms and manifestations, including the Pahalgam attack and the terror incident near Red Fort in Delhi last year, at a key meeting held here.

Both sides reaffirmed their commitment to strengthening counter-terrorism cooperation on bilateral as well as multilateral platforms.

During the 14th meeting of the India-Russia Joint Working Group on Counter Terrorism on Wednesday, the two sides also called for "concerted action against terrorists and terrorist groups, including those listed in the UNSC 1267 Sanctions Committee and their proxy groups and affiliates", the Ministry of External Affairs said on Thursday. The meeting was co-



Ministry of External Affairs Secretary (West) Sibi George with Russia's Deputy Foreign Minister Dmitry Lyubinsky during the 14th Meeting of India-Russia Joint Working Group on Counter Terrorism, in New Delhi

chaired by Sibi George, Secretary (West) in the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA), and Dmitry Lyubinsky, Deputy

HIGHLIGHTS

- » India and Russia have jointly condemned terrorism in all its forms and manifestations
- » Both sides reaffirmed their commitment to strengthening counter-terrorism cooperation on bilateral as well as multilateral platforms
- » They discussed the current and emerging terrorist threats at the global and regional levels

Minister of Foreign Affairs of the Russian Federation, it said in a statement.

Representatives of relevant departments and agencies from both sides also participated in the meeting.

"Both sides condemned terrorism in all its forms and manifestations, including cross-border terrorism and condemned in the strongest terms the terrorist attack in Pahalgam, Jammu & Kashmir, India on April 22, 2025 and the terror incident near Red Fort, New Delhi on November 10, 2025," the MEA said.

"They called for concerted action against terrorists and terrorist groups, including those listed in the UNSC 1267 Sanctions Committee and their proxy groups and affiliates," it said.

The two sides also shared their experiences in countering terrorism and "agreed to enhance cooperation" to address challenges of violent extremism, radicalisation, terror financing and the use of new and emerging technologies and digital financial technologies for terrorist purposes,

the MEA said.

They discussed the current and emerging terrorist threats at the global and regional levels.

"Both sides reaffirmed their commitment to strengthening counter-terrorism cooperation in bilateral as well as multilateral platforms including at the UN, BRICS, EAG and SCO. The two sides agreed to hold the next meeting of the Joint Working Group on Counter Terrorism in Russia on a mutually convenient date," it added.

On April 22 last year, terrorists killed 26 people, mostly tourists, at Pahalgam in south Kashmir.

The dastardly act had shaken the nation and drawn condemnation from governments and leaders across the world.

On the evening of November 10 last year, a car explosion near the Red Fort complex in Delhi claimed 15 lives.

Wayanad landslide death toll rises to 6

Search ops underway for 2 missing



Search and rescue operation underway at the site of the landslide that struck the under-construction Anakkampoyil-Kalladi-Meppadi twin tunnel project, in Wayanad district, Thursday

MPOST BUREAU

WAYANAD (KERALA): The death toll in the Wayanad landslide rose to six on Thursday with the recovery of three more bodies from the disaster site, district officials said.

Search operations continued for the two persons still missing in the incident.

The three bodies recovered have been identified as those of migrant workers—Azharuddin Ansari, a surveyor from Uttar Pradesh; Rahul Sharma, an engineer from Himachal Pradesh; and Mohammed Imran, an excavator operator from Bihar, the officials said.

The two persons still missing are Rakesh Guchait, a surveyor from West Bengal, and Vikram Rana, a construction manager from Himachal Pradesh. Kerala Ministers A P Anil Kumar and T Siddique, who have camped in the area to coordinate the search operations, told reporters that one body was recovered from Zone 1 of the search area in the morning and the other two from Zone 3 near the river.

"Searches will be carried out in Zones 1 and 2 of the area. We will also focus the search operations near the river," Anil Kumar said.

Siddique said that post-mortems on the bodies would

be conducted at Vythiri Taluk Hospital and that they would be embalmed at the Kozhikode Government Medical College Hospital before being sent to their respective home states.

The district administration said that a 70-member team of the National Disaster Response Force, 110 Fire and Rescue Services personnel, and about 100 police officers were part of the search operation, in which 12 pieces of heavy earth-moving machinery, such as Hitachi excavators and JCB machines, were also being used.

The district administration also said that 57 families living in vulnerable areas had been relocated to two relief camps at Meppadi Polytechnic College and the Government UP School in Cheeral village. A landslide occurred on July 7 at the site of the Anakkampoyil-Meppadi tunnel project, which is intended to connect Wayanad and Kozhikode districts.

Chief Minister V D Sathesnan had said on Wednesday that the search operations would be given priority.

He had also said that, of the 10 persons injured in the incident, three had been discharged, four were still hospitalised but stable, and three others were in the ICU, of whom two were critical.

Mission Olympic 2036: Haryana to set up 11 sports centres, says CM

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday said the state will develop world-class sports infrastructure under its Mission Olympic 2036 vision to help Indian athletes win the maximum number of medals at the Olympic Games.

Chairing a review meeting on Mission Olympic 2036 in Chandigarh, Saini announced that 11 sports centres will be established in the first phase with an estimated investment of around Rs 800 crore. Minister of State for Sports Gaurav Gautam was also present at the meeting. The proposed centres will come up at the Sports University in Rai, State Sports Complex in Palwal, TDI Sports Complex in Panchkula, and facilities in Ambala and Kurukshetra. Sports complex private academies will also be developed



Haryana CM Nayab Saini chairs a meeting of the Sports department

in Karnal, Jind, Gohana and Yamunanagar.

The meeting focused on identifying and nurturing young talent, especially athletes in the 13-16 age group. The Chief Minister said the Sports University, Rai, has been designated as the nodal agency for the Olympic 2036 Talent Mission, which will function under the supervision of Sports Minister Gaurav Gautam.

Saini said around 1,200 young athletes will receive specialised training at these centres across various disciplines. The initiative will also prepare athletes for the 2028 Asian Games.

He added that Olympic medal-winning coaches will be engaged for training, while 23 additional sports centres with accommodation and dining facilities will also be developed.

CISF's Bengal, Jharkhand raids yield 428 tonnes of 'illegal coal'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) has stepped up its crack-down on illegal coal mining and transportation, recovering over 428 metric tonnes of illegally mined and stored coal in Jharkhand and West Bengal between July 4 and 8.

The recoveries were made during intelligence-driven raids conducted in coalfields operated by Bharat Coking Coal Limited (BCCL), Eastern Coalfields Limited (ECL) and Central Coalfields Limited (CCL) as part of the Government of India's "Zero Coal Leakage" campaign.

The operations were carried out in coordination with Coal India subsidiaries, local police and district administrations to curb illegal mining,



theft and unauthorised storage and transportation of coal.

During the five-day operation, the CISF registered four FIRs and seized one Hyva truck, more than 13 motorcycles and other equipment allegedly used in illegal mining and transport activities.

Of the total 428.34 tonnes of coal recovered, the largest seizure of 319.54 tonnes was made from the BCCL coalfields in Dhanbad. The recovery followed intelligence-based raids

supported by drone surveillance and field verification. A coal-laden truck and several motorcycles used for transporting stolen coal were also seized. In Sheetalpur under ECL, the CISF recovered 85.93 tonnes of illegally mined and stocked coal after inspecting coal depots, weighbridges and transit counters and verifying production and dispatch records.

Special operations in CCL's Piparwar area led to the recovery of 13.62 tonnes of hidden coal from a Hyva truck, while another 9.25 tonnes was seized in CCL Kargali, where seven motorcycles used for illegal mining were also impounded.

The CISF said it is using human intelligence, drone surveillance and GPS-based monitoring to curb illegal coal activities.

BORDER DISTRICT SPs' CONFERENCE

Shah calls for robust action to tackle infiltration

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday said India is working towards developing one of the world's most sophisticated border security systems based on the concept of 'Smart Borders' and reaffirmed the government's commitment to making the country infiltration-free through a comprehensive and proactive security strategy.

Addressing the Border District Superintendents of Police Conference-2026 in New Delhi, Shah said the meeting had evolved an integrated approach to border management and that similar plans would also be prepared to strengthen security along India's coastline.

The Home Minister said the government is developing



Home Minister Amit Shah chairs the Border District SPs Conference in New Delhi

a four-tier security grid comprising border guarding forces, state government agencies, the Centre and local communities. "A secure nation means secure borders, prosperous border villages and an empowered and vigilant border population," he said.

Highlighting the government's achievements, Shah said India has made signifi-

cant progress in tackling terrorism in Jammu and Kashmir, insurgency in the Northeast and Left Wing Extremism. He expressed confidence that concrete steps would be taken to dismantle the narcotics mafia within the next three years.

Shah said the government is creating a comprehensive mechanism to prevent infiltration and protect the coun-

try's borders, adding that unlike previous governments, the present dispensation was addressing issues at their roots. He said border infrastructure has expanded by nearly 400 per cent in recent years and highlighted the Vibrant Village Programme, aimed at preventing migration from border areas, creating employment opportunities and ensuring effective implementation of welfare schemes.

Referring to the recently launched Demography Mission, Shah said it would study abnormal demographic changes and their causes, including illegal infiltration, and help formulate policy responses. He also announced that a 1,610-km fence would be built along the India-Myanmar border at an estimated cost of Rs 31,000 crore.

Mahadev app cases: CBI files fresh chargesheets

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has filed fresh charge sheets in two cases linked to the alleged Mahadev betting app syndicate, naming several accused and adding charges against those believed to be the masterminds behind the illegal online betting network.

In the corruption case related to the Mahadev App, the agency has charge-sheeted six persons — Ashim Das, Rohit Gulati, Vikas Chhaparia, Anil Dhammani, Vishal Ahuja and Dheeraj Ahuja. They have been booked on charges of cheating, forgery and criminal conspiracy under various provisions of the Indian Penal Code (IPC).

The CBI has also submitted supplementary evidence against the alleged masterminds, Saurabh Chandrakar and Ravi Uppal, along with other accused who had already been charge-sheeted in the case.

In a separate but connected case, the agency has filed five additional charge sheets against 66 persons, including Chandrakar and Uppal and members of several panels allegedly used to route proceeds generated from the betting operations. The accused have been booked under various sections of the IPC and the Chhattisgarh Gambling Prohibition Act.

According to the CBI, the Mahadev App is among the country's largest illegal online betting syndicates and has been operating from outside India. The app allegedly gained popularity through social media promotions, attracting millions of registered users and facilitating illegal betting activities across the country.

The probe has revealed that the syndicate generated illicit revenues worth several crores of rupees, which were allegedly laundered through third-party bank accounts and later transferred abroad. Investigators also found that part of the proceeds was used to bribe public officials.

Lucknow, Delhi fire tragedies: Top Court pulls up civic bodies

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday came down heavily on civic authorities over unauthorised constructions in Delhi-NCR and recent fire tragedies in Delhi and Lucknow, warning that senior officials would be held personally liable for failing to comply with its directions.

A bench of Justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and R. Mahadevan sought the personal presence of officials from the Municipal Corporation of Delhi and civic bodies in Gurugram and Lucknow, expressing concern over their conduct and repeated non-compliance with court orders.

The court noted that little effective action had been

taken on its May 20 directions regarding the sealing, demolition and other legal measures against unauthorised structures. It made it clear that no "slackness" on the part of civic authorities would be tolerated and warned that suo motu contempt proceedings could be initiated against officials who failed to implement its orders.

The bench took on record status reports submitted by amicus curiae and senior advocate Ajit Sinha on recent fire incidents and action taken against illegal constructions.

Sinha told the court that the fires in Delhi's Malviya Nagar on June 3 and in Lucknow's Aliganj on June 22 were the result of multiple failures rather than a single lapse.

The Malviya Nagar fire

broke out in a narrow multi-storey building operating as a bed and breakfast facility with a restaurant on the ground floor. The blaze claimed 23 lives, most of them foreign nationals from countries including Nigeria, Bangladesh and Afghanistan, while more than 50 people were rescued.

The Aliganj fire in Lucknow killed 15 people, mostly students aged between 16 and 25, and injured several others.

Taking serious note of the incidents, the apex court said it had already issued specific directions regarding congested areas such as Lajpat Nagar and Sarojini Nagar and indicated that dangerous unauthorised structures should be demolished immediately to prevent further tragedies.

CHILD'S DISCLOSURE DEEMED CREDIBLE

POCSO case: Info given by minor victim must be reported, says SC

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Information received from a minor victim about sexual assault will be deemed credible and the recipient will be bound to report it to authorities including police under the POCSO Act, the Supreme Court on Thursday held. A bench of justices Manoj Misra and KV Viswanathan, which interpreted the question as to when can it be said that a person has knowledge that an offence under the POCSO Act has been committed, noted that the phrase "has knowledge that such an offence has been committed" is not limited to direct knowledge, but would include awareness of its commission based on direct information received from the minor victim.

"Therefore, for the purposes of this Act, when a child victim reports to a person that he or she has been subjected to an offence, or is likely to be subjected to an offence, punishable under the Act, it could safely be concluded that the person to whom such information is

KEY POINTS

- » The recipient will be bound to report it to authorities including police under the POCSO Act
- » The bench interpreted the question arising from a POCSO case related to a school in Arunachal, where an 8-yr-old girl



reported about the sexual assault allegedly by a school senior to her teachers, elder sister and classmates

provided by the child victim has knowledge that such an offence has been committed or is likely to be committed," the top court ruled.

The bench interpreted the question arising from a Prevention of Children from Sexual Offences Act (POCSO) case related to a school in Arunachal Pradesh, where an eight-year-old girl reported about the sexual assault allegedly by a school senior boy to her teachers, elder sister and classmates.

The bench said there may be instances where a child may report without understanding

the nature of the act to which the child has been subjected to.

"In such cases, and also where the information provided by the child is either not clear or confusing, a brief questioning of the child may be justified to derive a lucid picture of the nature of the information which the child wishes to convey. However, such questioning should not be with a view to rubbish the complaint made by the child, rather it must be to understand the true and correct nature of the complaint," it said.

The top court set aside the order of the Gauhati High

Man dies of Covid-19 in Andhra

KADAPA: A 46-year-old man died of Covid-19 here four days after treatment with antibiotics failed to control his symptoms, an official said on Thursday.

Kadapa District Medical & Health Officer Ravi Babu said the deceased was addicted to alcohol and had been admitted to a local hospital for severe breathlessness and cough.

"A 46-year-old man from Masapeta area in Kadapa succumbed to Covid-19. He was an alcoholic. He was suffering from severe breathlessness and cough," Babu said. An X-ray examination showed that both lungs of the deceased were completely damaged, resulting in pneumonia, the DM&HO said.

The disease did not subside even after four days of high-dose antibiotic treatment, prompting doctors to suspect a coronavirus infection, he said.

A subsequent CT scan of the chest confirmed the Covid-19 infection, Babu said, adding that containment measures — such as sanitisation and the tracing of primary and secondary contacts of the deceased — had been undertaken. AGENCIES

Nation Briefs

CBI, DRI BUST INTERSTATE WILDLIFE TRAFFICKING RACKET

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), in a joint operation with the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI), Mumbai, and the Wildlife Crime Control Bureau (WCCB), rescued 53 protected animals and birds and arrested six people in an interstate wildlife trafficking case. The operation followed inputs about an organised network involved in illegal trade of species protected under the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972. The rescued animals included 15 slow lorises, two binturongs, 28 star tortoises, six Egyptian vultures and two shikra birds. The CBI registered two cases on July 7 and 8 and arrested three accused each from Mumbai and Kolkata.

SC MULLS LARGER BENCH REFERENCE IN MEGHALAYA HONEYMOON MURDER CASE

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday said it might refer to a larger bench the legal question whether the mere mention of a wrong statutory section in an arrest memo, specifically a typographical error, was sufficient to invalidate an arrest and grant bail to Sonam Raghuvanshi in the murder case of her husband. A partial working day bench comprising Justices Manoj Misra and Shree Chandrashekhkar also indicated that it would closely examine whether the Meghalaya High Court was justified in granting bail to Raghuvanshi on the grounds that the arrest memo contained a typographical error.



EDITORIAL
RESOURCE
RACE

The Arctic is no longer a distant, frozen frontier at the edge of global politics. It has become one of the world's most consequential strategic theatres, where climate change, great-power rivalry and technological competition are converging. At the centre of this transformation stands Greenland, an island of barely 56,000 inhabitants but immense geopolitical significance. United States President Donald Trump's repeated insistence that Greenland should come under American control has reignited a debate that extends far beyond one island or one presidency. While his rhetoric has alarmed allies and unsettled diplomatic norms, it has also exposed a reality that many policymakers have preferred to ignore: the Arctic is rapidly becoming a decisive arena in the emerging global order. The question, however, is not whether Greenland matters strategically—it unquestionably does—but whether strategic necessity can ever justify overriding the principles of sovereignty, self-determination and alliance solidarity that have underpinned international stability for decades.

Greenland's value is rooted primarily in geography. Situated between North America and Europe and stretching deep into the Arctic Circle, the island has long served as a military outpost guarding the North Atlantic. During the Second World War, it became vital to protecting Allied shipping routes, while throughout the Cold War it functioned as a crucial early-warning station against Soviet missile threats. Today, the United States already operates the strategically important Pituffik Space Base, supporting missile defence, space surveillance and NATO operations. Greenland also overlooks the Greenland-Iceland-United Kingdom (GIUK) Gap, a maritime chokepoint critical to monitoring Russian submarine activity. Yet the island's significance has expanded dramatically because climate change is reshaping the Arctic itself. Shrinking sea ice is gradually opening previously inaccessible shipping routes, potentially shortening trade links between Asia, Europe and North America. Simultaneously, melting ice is exposing vast deposits of rare earth elements and other critical minerals indispensable for semiconductors, electric vehicles, renewable energy technologies and advanced defence systems. Geography that was once frozen into strategic irrelevance is now becoming central to the economic and military competition of the twenty-first century.

The renewed interest in Greenland must also be understood within the broader framework of intensifying rivalry among the world's major powers. Russia has steadily rebuilt its Arctic military infrastructure, modernised old Soviet-era bases and strengthened the capabilities of its Northern Fleet. China, although geographically distant, has declared itself a "near-Arctic state" and incorporated the region into its ambitious Polar Silk Road initiative, seeking future commercial access while expanding its global strategic footprint. Western governments, meanwhile, remain increasingly concerned about China's overwhelming dominance in processing rare earth minerals, creating vulnerabilities in supply chains essential for high-technology industries. These developments have understandably pushed Arctic security higher on the agenda of NATO and Western capitals. However, recognising Greenland's importance should not be confused with endorsing unilateral acquisition. The United States already enjoys extensive military access through agreements with Denmark and Greenland, and security experts themselves have noted that formal ownership would add little to Washington's existing strategic advantages. In reality, what is at stake is less about immediate defence requirements than about geopolitical symbolism and long-term resource competition in an increasingly contested Arctic.

That distinction is crucial because the methods employed by great powers often determine the legitimacy of their objectives. Denmark remains a long-standing NATO ally, while Greenland enjoys extensive self-government under the Danish Crown. Its elected leadership has consistently maintained that the island's future will be determined solely by the Greenlandic people. Suggestions of military force or territorial acquisition, even when later softened, undermine the very principles that democratic nations invoke when criticising similar behaviour elsewhere. If powerful states begin treating strategic geography as a commodity to be acquired rather than territory governed by international law and popular consent, the consequences will extend well beyond the Arctic. Such precedents weaken the credibility of alliances, encourage revisionist ambitions elsewhere and create unnecessary distrust among partners facing common security challenges. Ironically, they may also strengthen the narratives of rival powers who frequently accuse the West of applying different standards depending on whose interests are involved. Effective deterrence against Russia or strategic competition with China requires stronger alliances, not avoidable disputes within them.

Greenland therefore represents a defining test of how democracies respond to an era of renewed geopolitical competition. The Arctic undoubtedly demands greater investment, stronger infrastructure, scientific cooperation and coordinated security arrangements among like-minded nations. The region's critical mineral reserves should be developed responsibly to diversify global supply chains without sacrificing environmental safeguards or indigenous rights. Above all, the voices of Greenland's people must remain central to every decision concerning their future. Strategic importance does not erase the principles of sovereignty, nor should resource wealth become a licence for geopolitical opportunism. The Arctic's future will shape global trade, technological competition and military balance for generations to come. Whether it becomes another theatre of confrontation or an example of responsible international cooperation will depend on whether nations choose partnership over possession, diplomacy over coercion, and international law over the temptations of power politics.

STATECRAFT
TODAY



G PALANITHURAI

THE WRITER IS A FORMER PROFESSOR AND RAJIV GANDHI CHAIR FOR PANCHAYATI RAJ STUDIES, GANDHIGRAM RURAL INSTITUTE

Recent directions issued to Tamil Nadu's bureaucracy raise larger questions about political interference, administrative culture and whether the Indian state ultimately serves the Constitution or the ruling party

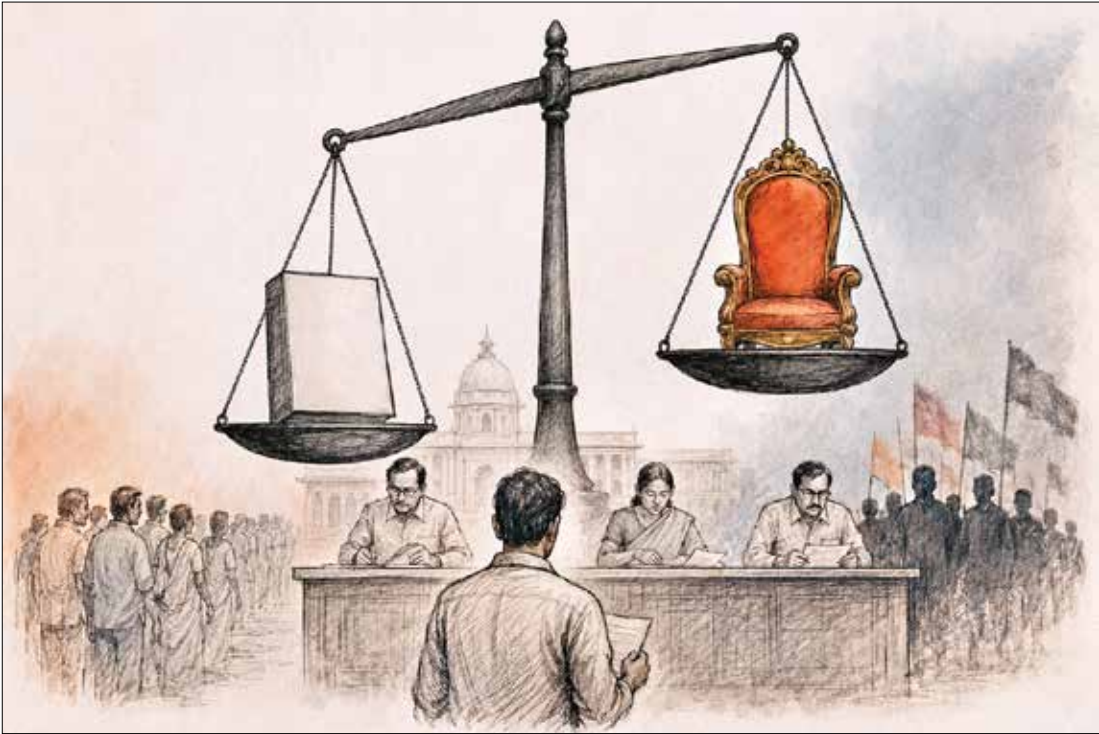
Party Power over Rule of Law?

Administrative neutrality and the dignity of ordinary citizens remain the strongest tests of whether constitutional governance truly prevails over partisan authority

Recently, the Government of Tamil Nadu organised a conference of District Collectors, during which the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu gave a few instructions to the officials. Of them, two are the most important points that capture the attention of public intellectuals. They are: one, law and order should be strictly enforced without any political interference. The second, which is more important than the first one, is that the officials have to treat the poor who come to government offices with a lot of grievances and petitions, and during that time they should be treated with utmost respect and respond to their grievances in a responsive way. No one should be belittled or disrespected during the visit of the public.

In this country, there is a practice in the bureaucracy that whoever comes with a petition is treated either as a beneficiary or a petitioner, and if they are poor, they cannot receive the respect that the rich get from officials. What we find in the community, we find the same behaviour in the offices, as individuals are oriented in the community social practices. When Dalit or women goes to government offices, they meet with disrespect from the officials. Those who are in the offices are highly educated, and they speak about democracy, yet equality is the casualty. As a result, the poor never feel that they have a voice in the nation, and they feel that they are secondary citizens. The poor believe that the officials make and unmake things in the governance system.

This has been the culture of bureaucracy in India in the past seven decades. If the poor come with party men's support, they will be responded to, and that is why they join the party or go to party men for help to get things done in the government offices. They never feel that officials will look into the petition in the backdrop of the merit of the petition. If people go with ruling party men or women, officials will look into it, and even if the petitions do not have any merit, they will be considered positively. If the



The real test of democracy lies inside government offices, not election rallies

poor go to offices without the support of a ruling party functionary, they will not be treated with dignity. What the citizens need first is respect. Dignity of the citizen has to be restored as per the Constitution of India. It is not the fault of the bureaucracy, but it is the fault of the political class which failed to inculcate the value of respecting every human being irrespective of their status and position. But at the same time, if they could not get respect in the government offices, the political class would make a hue and cry, whereas in the case of the poor, even the political class will also do the same thing except during the time of election. It is not only the bureaucracy but also the political class that is responsible for the poor treatment given to the poor and marginalised. In a country like India, what is more important is the change of behaviour among the political class and bureaucracy. It is

being emphasised in the meeting by the Chief Minister.

Secondly, in India there is yet another perception which is in the public sense. Whichever political party comes to power after the general election, be it for the state Legislature or National Parliament, people call it a party Government. It is not a party government. When they say it is X party government, party men and women feel, whatever we want to do, we can do. In such a way, the rule of law has been subjugated by the ruling party functionaries. Party men and women go to government offices and police stations and interfere in the day-to-day functioning of the officials and the police, and as a result, the rule of law becomes subservient to the ruling party's law.

For the above two things, the present government has put a full stop. There won't be any unlawful and ille-

gal activity in the state, and if any, it can be dealt with firmly. There will be no political interference. By doing so, corruption will be eliminated; people will feel that they are being respected and they can claim their entitlements as their rights. Further, no party men will go to the police station to protect the miscreants and criminals. Police have been given a free hand to deal with wrongdoers without any political interference.

As a result, the culture of the ruling party law has been given a go-by through the strong decision of the Chief Minister. Secondly, the provision given in the Constitution of India is amply stated in the preamble to the Constitution of India that the dignity of the citizens will be protected, and it is kept intact by giving a strong instruction to the officials to treat the poor with dignity.

Views expressed are personal

FUTURE
READY



PROBIR KUMAR GHOSH

THE WRITER IS THE VICE CHANCELLOR, VISVA-BHARATI (A CENTRAL UNIVERSITY)

Today, a student in a remote district can access lectures and courses from the country's finest institutions through platforms

Reimagining Higher Education

From new institutions to research reforms, higher education is steadily emerging as one of the strongest foundations for India's long-term transformation

Every generation leaves behind a defining legacy. For some, it is infrastructure. For others, it is economic reform. In Bharat's case, the last twelve years have increasingly been about investing in people, ideas and institutions that will shape the nation's future for decades to come. Higher education sits at the centre of that story.

Its transformation has not been driven by a single initiative or one flagship programme. It has unfolded across campuses, laboratories, classrooms and digital platforms, through new institutions, fresh policy-thinking, stronger research ecosystems and an expanding culture of innovation. At the heart of this transformation is a clear vision: to position Bharat as a global knowledge leader while ensuring that quality higher education reaches every region of the country.

The most visible change is physical. Since 2014, new IITs and IIMs have expanded the footprint of premier education across the country, while central universities, medical colleges and other institutions of national importance have widened access and created opportunities in regions that previously had limited exposure to such facilities. Continued investments across the North-East and other emerging education hubs underline a broader objective that excellence should not remain concentrated in a handful of cities but become a national reality.

Infrastructure, however, tells only part of the story.

The introduction of the National Education Policy 2020 marked a significant shift in the philosophy of higher education itself. Flexibility, multidisciplinary learning and students' choice have become central themes. Multiple entry and exit options, academic mobility and the Academic Bank of Credits are enabling learners to design educational journeys that are better aligned with their ambitions rather than fixed institutional pathways.

The emphasis has also shifted from simply awarding degrees to creating meaningful learning experiences. And technology is the most important enabler of this transition.

Today, a student in a remote district can access lectures and courses from the country's finest institutions through



Since 2014, new IITs and IIMs have expanded the footprint of premier education across the country

platforms such as SWAYAM. Universities are increasingly integrating online education into mainstream learning, while digital governance initiatives like SAMARTH are simplifying administration, improving transparency and making institutional management more efficient.

Research and innovation have become defining features of Bharat's higher education ecosystem, which has witnessed a decisive push towards strengthening scientific inquiry and innovation. Expanded support through the Prime Minister's Research Fellowship, CoEs in AI and the "One Nation One Subscription" initiative has improved access to world-class research resources and strengthened the country's academic capabilities.

The impact extends well beyond publications and laboratories. Cam-

puses are becoming spaces where ideas are translated into products, startups and practical solutions.

That evolution is visible in initiatives like Bharat Innovates, which seeks to connect promising technology ventures emerging from Indian HEIs with global investors, research organisations and industry leaders. Across universities and technical institutions, incubation centres, innovation hubs and entrepreneurship cells are encouraging students to think beyond conventional career paths and become creators of new opportunities.

Indian institutions are becoming increasingly visible in global rankings, with strong performances across subject-specific disciplines reflecting growing academic credibility and research strength. Bharat's record performance in recent QS rankings is another indica-

tor of this upward trajectory and of the sustained efforts being made to enhance institutional excellence.

Faculty development has remained equally important. Programmes such as the Malaviya Mission Teacher Training Programme and reforms in accreditation and quality assurance recognise a fundamental truth: world-class universities are ultimately built by world-class educators.

Another notable feature of this transformation is its emphasis on inclusion.

Efforts to expand multilingual education, improve access for Divyangjan learners and strengthen digital learning opportunities are helping widen participation across diverse communities. Initiatives like the Bharatiya Bhasha Pustak Yojana seek to make quality educational resources available in Indian languages, making knowledge more accessible and strengthening linguistic diversity within higher education.

Apprenticeship Embedded Degree Programmes, expanded National Apprenticeship initiatives and the growing presence of Professors of Practice are bringing practical experience directly into academic settings. Students now have greater opportunities to engage with industry experts, acquire workplace skills and connect classroom learning with real-world applications.

Bharat's engagement with the global academic community has also acquired fresh momentum. Reforms enabling foreign universities to establish campuses in Bharat, expanded dual-degree opportunities, streamlined equivalence mechanisms and the Study in India initiative are creating stronger international linkages while enhancing Bharat's standing as a global education destination.

The larger picture is becoming increasingly clear.

As Bharat advances towards the vision of Viksit Bharat@2047, higher education will remain one of its most powerful engines of progress. The emergence of a more connected, research-driven, globally engaged and student-focused higher-education ecosystem is not merely an educational milestone; it is an investment in Bharat's future as a leading knowledge economy and innovation powerhouse.

Views expressed are personal

HUGE CROWDS FILL STREETS IN IRAN FOR KHAMENEI'S FUNERAL

Bitterly divided Iran grapples with Khamenei's legacy as he is laid to rest

CAIRO: He is the grandson of an influential Shiite cleric, born in Qom — the heart of religious studies in Iran — and raised in a traditional family that embraced the theocracy.

But by his late 20s, he had stopped praying and given up on clerical rule. Now, he can barely discuss politics or religion with his siblings and father.

The tech worker, now in his mid-30s, says Iranian society is deeply divided, even among opponents of the Islamic Republic, and he blames one man — Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. The supreme leader who ruled Iran for over three decades will be laid to rest Thursday after being killed at the start of the war.

Processions of his coffin in Tehran and other cities brought out gigantic crowds of supporters in a show of strength by the hard-liners at the core of the Islamic Republic, who lionized him as a defender of clerical rule who had stood up to the West and Israel.



The flower petal-covered coffin of the late Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei being carried above mourners reaching out to touch it outside the Imam Hussein Shrine in Karbala on Thursday

AP/PTI

But underneath run deep veins of discontent that have grown over decades of bloody repression, international sanctions and economic mismanagement, and

have widened since authorities killed thousands of anti-government protesters in January.

“A gap has opened up in homes across the country that

is really remarkable,” said the tech worker by phone from Tehran, where he now lives. Like others interviewed by The Associated Press to discuss Khamenei’s rule, he spoke

Highlights

- » The supreme leader who ruled Iran for over three decades will be laid to rest after being killed at the start of the war
- » Khamenei’s death, in Israeli strikes on February 28, crowned his legacy in the eyes of Iran’s rulers and his supporters, who consider him a martyr

on condition of anonymity out of security fears.

Khamenei’s death, in Israeli strikes on February 28, crowned his legacy in the eyes of Iran’s rulers and his supporters, who consider him a martyr.

Echoing the slogans of ultra-hardliners who oppose talks with the US, some who turned out for the funeral called for US President Donald Trump to be killed in revenge.

AGENCIES

Andy Burnham on course to be new UK PM as election process begins

LONDON: Andy Burnham looks set for a so-called coronation as the next British Prime Minister as the process to elect a new Labour Party leader formally opened on Thursday.

The former Mayor of Greater Manchester and new member of Parliament for Makerfield remains the sole candidate in the race to succeed Keir Starmer, who announced his resignation last month and set the clock ticking for a new leader.



Andy Burnham

July 13 is earmarked for candidates to take part in a parliamentary hustings where they answer questions from Labour MPs

“I see our strength at home and our strength in the world as indivisible.

Through No. 10 North, and the devolution of power to all parts of the UK, we will take a new approach to regenerat-

ing and re-industrialising the country, and thereby strengthening its resilience.

“That same approach will consider foreign policy, economic policy, security, social cohesion and British values as inextricably linked elements of the same strategic question,” he stated.

The 56-year-old Labour MP has previously set out his plans for “No. 10 North” as symbolic of his efforts to devolve power to the regions of England beyond the centralised control at No. 10 Downing Street in London.

AGENCIES

South African protesters go door-to-door forcing immigrants from their homes

JOHANNESBURG: Groups of anti-immigration South Africans seized foreigners from their homes in Johannesburg on Thursday and handed them to police in a hardening of protests that have sown fear in

communities and strained ties with some countries.

In Johannesburg’s Alexandra township, a Reuters reporter saw protesters breaking down doors and entering houses where they believed

undocumented immigrants were hiding.

They escorted the people to police vans where they were taken away, including a woman and a small child from Malawi. Another man who was apprehended by the marchers told Reuters he was in the country legally.

“I am a ZEP holder,” said the Zimbabwean national, Total Mhlanga, referring to the Zimbabwean Exemption Permit which allows tens of thousands of nationals to live and work in South Africa.

In Soweto, anti-immigrant protesters marched through town wielding sticks and flags.

AGENCIES

Ukrainian drones batter Russian oil facilities, set more oil tankers ablaze

KYIV: Ukrainian drones on Thursday hit more Russian oil facilities and set two oil tankers ablaze in the Sea of Azov, a day after US President Donald Trump pledged to grant Ukraine a license to manufacture the Patriot air defence systems.

Ukraine’s strikes on oil refineries and other infrastructure across Russia has triggered a widespread fuel crisis with gasoline shortages and fuel rationing reported in multiple regions and drivers waiting for hours to fill their tanks.

Early Thursday, a Ukrainian drone strike triggered a fire at an oil depot in the city of Tver in western Russia, according to acting regional Gov Vitaly Korolyov.

And in the southern Stavropol region, Gov Vladimir Vladimirov said oil reservoir has been set ablaze by Ukrainian drones in Vyazniki. He said the authorities ordered the evacuation of residents of several apartment buildings near the facility as the fire expanded.

AGENCIES

Don’t support Tibetan independence: China to US

BEIJING: China on Thursday urged the US to honour its commitment to recognise Tibet as part of China and not to support Tibetan independence.

The US State Department said in a statement on Wednesday that it supports the aspirations of Tibetans to preserve their culture and called on China to return to dialogue with the Dalai Lama. Reacting to the US statement, China’s Foreign Ministry said that all Tibet-related issues are China’s “internal affairs.” China calls Tibet as Xizang.



“Xizang-related affairs are purely China’s internal affairs and no country has the right to make interference,” Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning told a media briefing here while responding to a question on the US statement on Thursday.

AGENCIES

China’s ballistic missile launch was message for US

BANGKOK: When China launched a ballistic missile into the South Pacific Ocean on Monday, it was a rare test of a nuclear-capable weapons system that drew international rebuke.

Arriving two years after a similar missile launch in international waters in the Pacific, the test by the People’s Liberation Army caught the attention of small island nations whose leaders have increasingly urged

bigger countries to stop using the vast oceanic region for power struggles. But Beijing’s message was largely for just one country, experts say: the United States. “The most important message is the PLA is becoming a powerful military with a very strong strategic nuclear capability,” said Tong Zhao, a senior fellow with the Nuclear Policy Programme at the Carnegie Endowment for Interna-

Key Points

- » China says the launch was part of annual exercises
- » It seems to warn that Beijing may conduct similar launches in the future

tional Peace, a think tank.

The test, launched from a

France returns 23 Syrian treasures after 15 years after Macron visit

DAMASCUS: France has finally returned 23 Syrian archaeological treasures that remained in the country for about 15 years after being loaned for an exhibition. Their return coincided with French President Emmanuel Macron’s landmark visit to Damascus — the first by a major Western leader since the ouster of Bashar Assad in late 2024.

The artifacts, flown aboard Macron’s presidential aircraft on Tuesday and returned to Syria’s National Museum, include Roman bronze objects, Byzantine and Islamic-era pieces and a richly coloured mosaic panel that once adorned the Umayyad Mosque. The collection was loaned in 2011 to an exhibition of Syrian antiquities at the Arab World Institute in Paris.

The Syrian Foreign Min-



French President Emmanuel Macron (left), Syrian President Ahmad al-Sharaa, and Syrian Foreign Minister Asaad al-Shaibani

AP/PTI

istry said that the artifacts belonged to museums in Damascus, Aleppo, Latakia and Palmyra and remained in France after diplomatic ties between the two countries were severed under Assad’s rule.

It described France as the first country to cooperate with Syria under a

nuclear-powered submarine, was a demonstration of the sea-based leg of China’s nuclear triad capability, which refers to the ability to have land, sea, and air-based nuclear systems.

Further, it showed that China’s military has what is called a second-strike capability, said Dominic Meagher, a research fellow at the Crawford School of Public Policy in Australia. That means even if China was

attacked first, it still has the ability to strike back, because the ability to fire could be anywhere, in the ocean or on land. Beijing said the launch was part of annual exercises, suggesting that it may conduct similar launches in the future. “I would see this as a systematic move, not an isolated event,” said K Tristan Tang, Nonresident Fellow at the National Bureau of Asian Research.

AGENCIES

Germany agreed to buy Tomahawk missiles: Merz

BERLIN: Germany has struck a deal with the United States to buy American-made Tomahawk cruise missiles and station them in Germany, Chancellor Friedrich Merz announced Thursday.

The German leader said the agreement on the long-range missiles, which are used to strike targets deep inside enemy territory, was reached this week on the sidelines of the NATO summit in Türkiye’s capital, Ankara.

“This will close an important strategic gap in our defence, and at the same time, we will work to develop our own European systems and station them in Europe,” Merz told parliament after returning from the two-day summit.

The deal struck with the Trump administration amounts to broader export

“THE PACT ON THE LONG-RANGE MISSILES WAS REACHED THIS WEEK ON THE SIDELINES OF THE NATO SUMMIT”

of American know-how to some of its major allies in Europe, whose security posture has been upended by Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine in early 2022.

On Wednesday, President Donald Trump said the US will give Ukraine a license to make Patriot air defence systems to counter missile attacks from Russia — a huge coup for Kyiv which has long requested the technology.

AGENCIES

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No.: 5220262027

Dated: 08.07.2026

E-Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)North Central Railway / Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites the following E-Tender on prescribed form for the following works up to 13.30 hrs. On 31.07.2026. The details of the tenders are as under:-

Tender No.: 117

Gem Bid No.: GEM/2026/B/7759610 Dated 08.07.2026

Name of work: Rendering service of maintenance in Kanpur area & Kanpur-Rura section under DEN/VPYJ for 01 years.

Approx.Cost of work (Rs.):1,70,38,324.00

Earnest Money (Rs.): 2,35,200.00

Completion period: 12 Months

Date of opening of tender: 31.07.2026

Similar work for Eligibility Criteria: Any Civil Engineering work

Note: 1. Tender on line can be submitted up to the due date of tender opening i.e. 31.07.2026. 2. The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website www.gem.gov.in up to the due date of tender opening i.e. 31.07.2026. 1566/26 (PH)

North central railways

cp@PCNCR

www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Nishika Sarwan D/o Vinod Sarwan R/o WZ-84, Street No. 1, Nasir Pur Road, Palam Extension Part-II, Palam Village, Delhi 110045, Mobile-9654369148** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **CC No. 345/2023 U/S 138 NI Act, PS Patel Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest their upon issued that the said accused **Nishika Sarwan** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Nishika Sarwan** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Nishika Sarwan** of **CC No. 345/2023 U/S 138 NI Act, PS Patel Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **12.08.2026**

By Order,

Sh. Anshul Singhal
Judicial Magistrate First Class- 04
West District, Room 268
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/9422/CD/2026(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr PC/84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Ram Kumar S/o Nand Lal R/o H.No.28/75A Kasturba Nagar Shahadra Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 347/2018 U/s 33/52 Excise Act at PS: Vivek Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Ram Kumar** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ram Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Ram Kumar** of **FIR No. 347/2018 U/s 33/52 Excise Act of PS: Vivek Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **10.08.2026**.

By order

Mohit Sharma
Judicial Magistrate First Class
Shahadra District Court No: 59, 3rd Floor
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/9379/SHD/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

No. 128-W/280/e Tender Notice/NIT-21-26-27-W-II

Dated :- 08.07.2026

The Sr. Divisional Engineer-II, Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites E-Tender for the following work.

1. NIT -21

Name of work:- 1. Provision of new RPF/GRP barracks, upgradation of existing RPF/GRP thana & barracks in the section of ADEN/MUT. and 2. Construction of new crew and train manager lobby at Ghaziabad with various facilities to running staff under ADEN/GZB in jurisdiction of Sr. DEN-II/DLI. **Approx cost of work:-** 44007465.46 **Earnest Money to be deposited:-** 880200.00

2. Date & Time of opening of tender

04.08.2026 15:00 Hrs.

3. Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen

www.ireps.gov.in

• The tenderer/s must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement system (IREPS) site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for participating in the e-tender system. • For all terms and conditions please refer tender document. • No manual offers are acceptable. • Cost of tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only. 2362/26

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE

ICICI Bank

Branch office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice. Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	M/s. Kosmosys Solutions Private Limited/ Manjusha Jain/ Parul Jain/ Pradeep Jain/ 135905001435	Freehold Built-Up Property No.IX/2243, Bearing Ahata No.07, Measuring Area 140.00 Sq. Yrds, Consisting of Its Whole of Structure, Built Thereon, With Complete Terrace/Roof Rights, With Rights of Upper Construction Up to The Last Storey, Fitted With Electricity, Tap Water With Meters, Out of Khosra No.25, Situated At Abadi of Street No.10, Near Shiv Mandir, (Panna Park), Kailash Nagar, In The Area of Village Seelampur, Illaqa Shahdara, Delhi, 110031., Owned By Pradeep Jain, Parul Jain, (Admeasuring An Area of 140.00 Sq. Yrds North: Other'S Property South: Other'S Property East: Road West: Road/ Date of Symbolic Notice 06 July, 2026	March 18, 2026 Rs. 2,70,40,328.00/-	Delhi

The above-mentioned borrower(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002. Date: July 10, 2026 Sincerely Authorised Officer, For ICICI Bank Ltd.

CAVEAT NOTICE

IN THE HIGH COURT OF JUDICATURE AT BILASPUR (CHHATTISGARH)

CAVEATOR

Nava Raipur Atal Nagar Vikas Pradhikaran, (NRANVP)

NON-CAVEATOR

General Public

VERSUMS

CAVEAT UNDER SECTION 148-A OF THE CODE OF CIVIL PROCEDURE, 1908 READ WITH RULE 142 OF THE HIGH COURT OF CHHATTISGARH RULES

The caveator most humbly and respectfully begs to submit as infra:

1. That, tenders have been invited vide NIT No. 26/TPS/EECS/CE/NRANVP/2026-27 and System Tender No.: 194807, dated 01/07/2026 titled "Selection of Developer for Development of Infrastructure of the Town Development Scheme (TDS) in Layer-II of Nava Raipur Atal Nagar in Lieu of Development Rights/ Selling Rights of Mixed-Use Land" (2nd call). The caveator, through this tender seeks to appoint a developer for Infrastructure Development of a Town Development Scheme (TDS) sanctioned under Section 50 (8) of the Chhattisgarh Nagar Tatha Gram NiveshAdhiniyam, 1973 published vide Gazette Notification dated 12/01/2026.

2. That, the caveator apprehends that anyone from the general public, may file a writ petition either challenging the tender or the subsequent developments/actions taken in furtherance of the said tender. Therefore, this instant caveat is being preferred so that in case any such writ petition is filed, then the caveator may kindly be afforded an opportunity to represent and defend himself before any order is passed in the said case.

samvad 48404/4

CEO (NRANVP)

India’s oil imports insulated from crisis around Hormuz

‘Impact on India’s oil supplies is likely to be limited as refiners have diversified their sourcing in past few years’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India’s crude oil imports remain well insulated from the latest tensions around the Strait of Hormuz, although prolonged instability could disrupt LPG and LNG supplies and raise shipping costs, according to a Kpler analyst.

The latest exchange of fire in the region, following US President Donald Trump’s comments on a ceasefire, has renewed concerns over the security of one of the world’s busiest energy shipping lanes.

However, the impact on India’s crude supplies is likely to be limited because refiners have diversified their sourcing over the past few years, Sumit Ritolia, who models refinery and oil markets at Kpler, said.

“Crude flows through the Strait had not fully recovered before the latest escalation. For India, however, it has largely been business as usual over the past 100 days, with refiners successfully managing supply through a diversified import portfolio,” Ritolia said.

Russia continues to account for a significant share of India’s crude imports, while supplies from Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates routed through bypass infrastruc-



‘Crude flows through the Strait had not fully recovered before the latest escalation. For India, however, it has largely been business as usual over the past 100 days’

HIGHLIGHTS

- » ‘Russia continues to account for a significant share of India’s crude imports, while supplies from Saudi Arabia and the UAE routed through bypass infrastructure provide additional supply security’
- » ‘West African and Latin American grades have also helped diversify refinery feedstock’
- » Russian crude imports climbed to about 2.7 million bpd, accounting for more than half of India’s total crude imports during the month of June

ture provide additional supply security. West African and Latin American grades have also helped diversify refinery feedstock, he said.

India’s crude oil imports rose to a record 4.93 million barrels per day (bpd) in June, driven by a sharp increase in purchases from Russia as refiners sought to bolster supplies amid disruptions around the Strait of Hormuz.

Russian crude imports climbed to about 2.7 million bpd, accounting for more than half of India’s total crude imports during the month, cementing Russia’s position as the country’s largest oil supplier by a wide margin.

Ritolia said cargoes that can safely transit the Strait of Hormuz are still expected to move, although freight rates and insurance costs could increase

if regional tensions persist.

He added that Iranian crude was unlikely to emerge as a meaningful source of supply for Indian refiners despite any potential disruptions.

“Uncertainty around US sanctions policy, compliance risks, and commercial considerations means Iranian barrels are unlikely to become a meaningful part of India’s crude slate in the near term,” he said.

Instead, Ritolia said markets should focus more closely on liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) and liquefied natural gas (LNG), which have fewer short-term alternatives and remain more vulnerable to Gulf supply and shipping disruptions.

“A prolonged period of instability could tighten availability, increase freight costs, and add pressure to regional prices again, as we have seen over the last few months,” he noted.

“For now, India’s crude supply story remains one of diversification and resilience, not immediate scarcity. The key variables to watch are how long regional tensions persist, the impact on shipping and insurance costs, and whether LPG and LNG markets begin to experience more meaningful disruptions.”

Adani to file affidavit in US court this week

US District Judge Nicholas Garaufis asked Adani to state whether he is aware of any promise, offer, agreement or benefit connected to the dismissal

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Billionaire Gautam Adani will file this week a sworn affidavit in a US federal court stating whether he is aware of any promise, agreement or benefit linked to the US government’s decision to dismiss a criminal indictment against him.

US District Judge Nicholas Garaufis directed Adani to file the affidavit by July 15 before ruling on the Justice Department’s motion to dismiss the indictment with prejudice.

The judge asked Adani to state whether he is aware of any promise, offer, agreement or benefit connected to the dismissal, or of any exchange made in return for the charges being dropped.

Sources said Adani is likely to file the affidavit this week.

The Adani group did not offer any comment on the issue, saying the matter is sub judge.

The order of June followed a filing by Principal Associate Deputy Attorney General in the Department of Justice, R Trent McCotter, who said he was the “final and sole decision-maker” behind the dismissal and denied media reports that the decision was linked to Adani Group’s plans to invest about \$10 billion in the United States.

“The current or former Department attorneys... have suggested that I sought dis-



Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani

The judge directed Adani to file the affidavit by July 15 before ruling on the Justice Department’s motion to dismiss the indictment with prejudice

KEY POINTS

- » Order of June followed a filing by Principal Associate Deputy Attorney General in the DoJ, R Trent McCotter, who said he was ‘final & sole decision-maker’ behind dismissal
- » He denied media reports that decision was linked to Adani Group’s plans to invest about \$10 billion in the US
- » The judge noted that Adani’s lawyers had previously explained why defendants consented to govt’s motion to dismiss but made no reference to any agreement

missal of the securities charges at least in part because of some promise by those defendants to invest money in the United States. That is false,” McCotter wrote.

“I would have sought dismissal of the securities charges regardless of any mentions of investments,” he added.

“The mention of potential investments could not have played any role.”

McCotter said he decided to seek dismissal because the securities fraud case was legally “indefensible,” arguing that most of the alleged con-

duct occurred in India, Indian authorities had investigated the matter and found no actionable misconduct, investors suffered no losses, key evidence and witnesses were outside the United States, and the defendants were unlikely to appear before a US court.

He also said the Foreign Corrupt Practices Act charges no longer aligned with the Trump administration’s enforcement priorities, which focus on cases involving US national security, American companies or transnational criminal

organisations.

“The decision to seek dismissal was not a close call,” McCotter wrote, adding that the FCPA charges “should have been dismissed a year ago.”

Garaufis, however, said McCotter’s filing introduced, “for the first time,” the possibility that some form of agreement involving one or more defendants may have existed in connection with the dismissal, even though no such arrangement had been disclosed to the court.

The judge noted that Adani’s lawyers had previously explained why the defendants consented to the government’s motion to dismiss but made no reference to any agreement, including one involving a commitment to invest in the United States.

Before granting the government’s request under Rule 48 (a), the court said it must be satisfied that the Justice Department’s stated reasons are genuine and that no undisclosed agreement influenced its decision.

The Justice Department moved to dismiss charges brought in 2024 under the Biden administration, accusing Adani and seven others of participating in a scheme to pay about \$250 million in bribes to Indian officials to secure power supply contracts and mislead investors while raising capital from US markets. Adani has denied the allegations.

Facilitate greater access to credit for MSMEs: Min

NEW DELHI: Union MSME Minister Jitan Ram Manjhi urged banks to facilitate greater access to institutional credit for micro, small and medium enterprises and called upon all stakeholders to ensure effective implementation of government initiatives for the sector growth.

The minister visited Puducherry on July 8-9 to review the implementation of flagship schemes of the MSME Ministry and directed stakeholders to facilitate MSME access to technology, credit & finance, skill development, market access and quality support infrastructure.

During the visit, he chaired a comprehensive review meeting attended by officials of the ministry, Puducherry government, Development & Facilitation Office, Khadi and Village Industries Commission, Coir Board, National Small Industries Corporation, SIDBI, members of the State Level Bankers’ Committee, MSME associations and other stakeholders.

“Discussions were focused on improving awareness and greater uptake of these schemes,” an official statement said.

The MSME minister urged banks to facilitate greater access to institutional credit for MSMEs and called upon all stakeholders to ensure effective implementation of government initiatives for the sector growth, it added. PFI

TCS June quarter net profit rises 4.61% to ₹13,349 cr, bags new deals worth \$9.5 billion

MUMBAI: India’s largest IT services company TCS on Thursday reported a 4.61 per cent increase in its net profit to Rs 13,349 crore for the June 2026 quarter.

In the results, which came amid heightened worries over the growth sustenance in the \$315 billion domestic IT sector in the age of artificial intelligence, TCS said its net income rose 8.5 per cent year-on-year to Rs 13,849 crore, excluding exceptional items.

From a topline perspective, its Q1 revenues jumped by nearly 14 per cent year-on-year to Rs 72,275 crore, and edged up 2.23 per cent from the March quarter’s Rs 70,698 crore.

It reported an annualised AI revenue of \$2.6 billion, up 13.6 per cent quarter-on-quarter.

Its chief executive and managing director K Krithivasan said the quarter reflects continued growth momentum and the strength of our strategic positioning, despite geopolitical and macroeconomic headwinds.

“As customers accelerate investments in AI, modernisation, cybersecurity, sovereign cloud and platform simplification, our strong deal conversion, improving client mining and expanding ecosystem partnerships position TCS well to translate opportunity into sustained growth,” Krithivasan added.

The company said it has bagged \$9.5 billion of total contract value (TCV) or new deals in Q1, including a \$800 million AI-led transformation mega deal with SKF.

Its chief operating officer

Aarthi Subramanian noted that it signed strategic partnerships with Anthropic and Mistral to expand its AI ecosystem.

From a financial perspective, it reported an operating profit margin of 24 per cent during April-June compared to 25.3 per cent in the preceding quarter, which was expected to go down, given wage hikes and new investments.

The headcount rose by over 9,200 staffers in the three months to June to 5,93,798 employees as of June 30, it said, adding that long-term attrition in the IT services came at 13.6 per cent.

“We continue to invest in AI infrastructure, next-generation skill development platforms, to enable our people to be future ready, while fostering a workplace where every asso-

ciate feels safe, valued, trusted and empowered to grow,” its chief human resources officer Sudeep Kunnumal said.

From a sectoral perspective, all domains reported growth in revenue year-on-year, except the consumer business, and from a geographic perspective, Latin America and the UK reported lower revenues in Q1 FY27 against Q1 FY26.

Its India revenues, which had been on a decline following the culmination of the multi-thousand crore BSNL deal, jumped 22.9 per cent year-on-year and 7.6 per cent quarter-on-quarter.

The company scrip ended the session 0.52 per cent down at Rs 2,047.75 apiece on the BSE on Thursday against a 0.31 per cent jump on the benchmark. PFI

Govt waives basic customs duty on key inputs for electronics mfg

NEW DELHI: The government has waived basic customs duty on goods used in the manufacturing of display assemblies, lithium-ion cells and inductor coil modules as it looks to promote domestic production of electronic devices like smartphones, laptops, wearables and smart TVs.

The finance ministry issued three separate notifications giving effect to the basic customs duty waiver on the goods used in the manufacture of the three key components used in electronic devices. This exemption is in line with the government’s efforts to promote domestic electronics manufacturing under the PLI scheme.

The duty waiver would reduce import dependence and strengthen the electronics ecosystem with local produc-



tion. The exemptions on inputs used in display assemblies and inductor coil modules would be valid till March 31, 2029, the notifications said.

AMRG Global Managing Partner Rajat Mohan said the government has now consolidated separate customs exemptions for machinery used in the manufacture of lithium-ion cells for mobile handsets and electric vehicles into a single technology-neutral exemption applicable to machinery used for the manufacture of ‘lithium-ion cells’.

“This simplifies the customs framework, removes end-use-based distinctions, and significantly reduces compliance and interpretational challenges for manufacturers,” Mohan said.

The amendment is expected to encourage fresh investments in domestic lithium-ion cell manufacturing by providing greater flexibility to manufacturers operating integrated production facilities. “The biggest beneficiaries will be battery gigafactories, EV manufacturers, consumer electronics companies, battery energy storage system manufacturers, renewable energy projects, telecom infrastructure providers, data centres, medical device manufacturers, drone makers & industrial automation sectors,” Mohan added. PFI

SBI MF confident of ₹11,600 crore IPO success, eyes \$5 bn global AUM

MUMBAI: SBI Funds Management, which is set to launch its maiden public offering, is confident of successfully sailing through its Rs 11,600-crore IPO despite market volatility, the company’s top management said on Thursday.

The asset manager has fixed a price band of Rs 545-574 per share for the issue and plans to double its international business book to \$5 billion in the next three years from the current \$2.5 billion as part of its growth strategy. SBI Funds Management Managing Director and CEO Debasish Mishra said investor response to the IPO has been encouraging, adding that the company’s strong trust among customers will support

the issue despite uncertain market conditions. The IPO comes at a time when primary market activity has slowed following geopolitical tensions and broader market volatility. SBI MF’s offering is among the largest recent IPOs and will be followed by proposed mega listings of NSE and Jio Platforms.

The company said its revenue profile is affected by managing Employee Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) money, which generates lower fees. However, it is working to diversify revenue streams and reduce the share of EPFO assets in its overall assets under management (AUM).

SBI MF’s total AUM stands above Rs 13 lakh crore, includ-

ing more than Rs 3 lakh crore of EPFO assets. Deputy MD and Joint CEO D P Singh said the fund house’s share in EPFO money has declined to 26 per cent from 75 per cent earlier.

The company is also focusing on expanding its international operations with its partner Amundi, strengthening presence in financial hubs such as New York, London, Hong Kong and Singapore. It is exploring opportunities in alternative investments and may consider acquisitions if suitable opportunities arise.

The management said over one-fifth of SBI MF’s sales come through its parent State Bank of India, with no concerns over mis-selling of products. AGENCIES



The Government of Jharkhand and Ambuja Cement signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) during the National Stakeholders Consultation 2026 for an investment of Rs 1,000 crore.



J&K Bank on Thursday signed a strategic MoU with the Directorate of Census Operations, J&K and Ladakh to collaborate on media, publicity and public awareness activities for the upcoming Population Enumeration phase of Census 2027 in the UTs of J&K and Ladakh. This MoU was inked by Chief General Manager Ashutosh Sareen on behalf of J&K Bank, while Chief Principal Census Officer (PCPO) and Director Census Operations (DCO) Amit Sharma (IAS) put in his signatures on behalf of the Directorate of Census Operations J&K and Ladakh in the presence of Joint PCPO Arun Kumar, Deputy PCPO Manmeet Singh Loomba, Bank’s General Manager Mohammad Muzaffar Wani & DGM Syed Aadil Bashir.

National Stakeholders’ Consultation: Jharkhand attracts ₹99,639 cr investment in industry, technology, tourism

In the tourism sector, collaborations were established with TATA Motors & EaseMyTrip Planners

RANCHI: During the valedictory session of the National Stakeholders’ Consultation, a total of 14 Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs) were signed, attracting a proposed industrial investment of Rs 99,639 crore.

Under the Department of Industries, landmark investment agreements were executed with leading companies, including M/s Jindal Steel Ltd. (Rs 40,000 crore) and M/s Jindal Nuclear Power Pvt. Ltd. (Rs 30,000 crore), reaffirming inves-



tors’ confidence in Jharkhand’s growth potential.

To strengthen the State’s digital ecosystem and governance framework, strategic partnerships were formalised with M/s

Google Cloud and the Wadhvani Group for the expansion of technology infrastructure and e-Governance initiatives.

In the tourism sector, pioneering collaborations were

established with M/s TATA Motors for the promotion of Mining Tourism and with M/s EaseMyTrip Planners to enhance tourism promotion and visitor outreach.

These partnerships underscore the Government’s commitment to fostering investment, accelerating innovation and positioning Jharkhand as a leading destination for industry, technology and sustainable tourism.

Under the auspicious presence of Chief Minister Hemant

Soren and these MoUs were signed. On this occasion Minister Deepika Pandey, Minister Sanjay Prasad Yadav, Minister Sudivya Kumar and Minister Irfan Ansari were present.

Chief Secretary Avinash Kumar, Development Commissioner Ajay Kumar Singh was also there.

MoUs were signed by the Secretary IT Pooja Singhal, Secretary, Industry Arava Rajkamal and Secretary Tourism Mukesh Kumar and the representative of the firm concerned. MPOST

Housing sales stabilise at 1.71 lakh units in H1 2026: Knight Frank

NEW DELHI: Housing sales across eight major Indian cities remained largely stable in the first half of 2026, rising 0.7 per cent annually to 1.71 lakh units, as demand moderated after four years of strong post-pandemic growth, according to Knight Frank India.

The real estate consultant reported that residential sales increased to 1,71,471 units during January-June 2026 from 1,70,201 units in the year-ago period.

The data covered Mumbai, Delhi-NCR, Bengaluru, Pune, Hyderabad, Chennai, Ahmedabad and Kolkata.

Premium homes priced above Rs 1 crore accounted for 54 per cent of total sales, reflecting a shift in buyer preference towards higher-value properties.

Meanwhile, demand for affordable and mid-income housing weakened due to limited new supply.

Sales of affordable homes priced below Rs 50 lakh declined 15 per cent to 32,063 units, accounting for 19 per cent of overall sales. The Rs 50 lakh-Rs 1 crore segment saw a 5 per cent fall in sales to 46,490 units.

Knight Frank said sales

increased in all tracked cities except Delhi-NCR, which recorded a 7 per cent annual decline.

New housing launches rose 4 per cent during the period to 1,87,350 units. The consultant said the market has moved into a stabilisation phase after a broad-based recovery following the pandemic-led downturn in 2020.

“While growth has reduced following a steep recovery from pandemic lows, the market’s underlying fundamentals remain firmly intact,” said Shishir Bajjal, CMD, Knight Frank India. AGENCIES

Modi invites Australian bizs to tap into India’s growth opportunities

Modi addressed Australia-India CEOs Forum and Economic Roadmap Business event ahead of his talks with Australian PM Anthony Albanese

MELBOURNE: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday pitched for early finalisation of the proposed India-Australia Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement (CECA), saying it will propel bilateral economic ties to a “new level”.

In an address at a business forum, Modi also invited Australian companies to invest in India, saying it offers “unmatched opportunities” for growth in sectors such as aviation, financial services, critical minerals, technology and food processing.

The prime minister landed in Australia on Wednesday on a three-day visit that is largely aimed at boosting defence, energy and trade ties.

Modi addressed the Australia-India CEOs Forum and the Economic Roadmap Business event ahead of his talks with Australian Prime Minister Anthony Albanese.

Leading Indian and Australian CEOs and business leaders, representatives of major Australian superannuation funds and institutional investors, and Vice-Chancellors of leading Australian universities participated in the two events.

Modi welcomed an announcement by Chief Exec-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi addresses the gathering during the India-Australia CEOs Forum, in Melbourne, Australia

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Modi welcomed announcement by Chief Executive of AustralianSuper Paul Schroder, that the company will invest 500 mn AUD in India
- » To expand the business ties to a new level, Modi called for early conclusion of the proposed CECA

utive of AustralianSuper Paul Schroder, that the company will invest 500 million Australian dollars (AUD) in India.

“This is yet another glimpse of the global confidence in India’s growth and reform trajectory. It also reflects the immense opportunities that our dynamic economy offers global investors,” Modi said.

AustralianSuper is Australia’s largest super fund and it manages over USD 410 billion of retirement savings on behalf of over 3.6 million people, according to the company.

In his remarks, Modi expressed satisfaction over the growth of trade and investment between the two countries fol-

lowing the sealing of the Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement (ECTA) in 2022.

To expand the business ties to a new level, Modi called for early conclusion of the proposed CECA. Both sides are working towards a mutually beneficial CECA.

In the CEOs Forum, the prime minister highlighted that India’s strong economic growth, policy reforms, digital transformation, and expanding innovation ecosystem were creating new business opportunities for Australian partners.

Noting the complementarities between the Indian and Australian economies, Modi underlined that vast opportuni-

ties are available in India across manufacturing, clean energy, critical minerals, mining, infrastructure, urban development, aviation, logistics, advanced technologies, artificial intelligence, fintech, food processing and digital economy sectors.

He stated that India’s scale and Australian expertise make for a win-win proposition. Modi invited Australian investors to take advantage of the opportunities for long-term investments in India.

The prime minister welcomed the growing presence of Australian universities in India and highlighted that deeper collaboration in higher education, research, innovation and skill

development would not only make talent in both countries future-ready, but also help them to tap into global opportunities.

Following the CEOs Forum, PM Modi addressed the Economic Roadmap business event, a larger gathering of over 200 CEOs and business leaders from both sides.

Speaking about natural synergies between India and Australia, he highlighted that shared democratic values, a common vision for the Indo-Pacific, vibrant people-to-people ties and strong political understanding created fertile ground for the business partnership between the two countries.

Expressing satisfaction at the growth of trade and investment ties based on the Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement (ECTA) of 2022, he called for the early conclusion of the proposed CECA, so as to propel business ties to a new level.

He urged the business leaders to leverage complementary strengths on both sides and create global solutions, especially in the fields of rare earths, lithium, batteries, electronics, electric vehicles, semiconductors, AI and defence supply chains.

AGENCIES

CITES HIGHER ENERGY PRICES

ADB trims India’s FY27 growth projection to 6.6% from 6.9%

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Asian Development Bank on Thursday lowered India’s GDP growth projection to 6.6 per cent as against 6.9 per cent estimated earlier for the current fiscal on concerns of higher energy prices fuelled by the Middle East crisis.

Despite the growth moderation, India still continues to be the fastest-growing major economy in the world. India’s GDP growth forecasts are revised down to 6.6 per cent for FY2026 (ending 31 March 2027) and maintained at 7.3 per cent for FY2027, Asian Development Outlook (ADO) July 2026 said.

“The FY26 (2026-27) forecast is lowered from 6.9 per cent projected in April, reflecting elevated energy prices, which squeeze real incomes.

Growth will be supported by policy interventions to attract more foreign capital, as well as fuel tax cuts, targeted credit support, strong services exports, and public capital expenditure,” it said. The FY27 growth forecast remains unchanged from April, underpinned by improved global conditions and export competitiveness gained through trade agreements with various partners, it said.

However, it said, risks tilt to the downside, driven by heightened geopolitical tensions or weather-induced weakness in agriculture. With regard to inflation, the latest ADO has raised its inflation forecast



The FY27 growth forecast remains unchanged at 7.3%, Asian Development Outlook (ADO) July 2026 said

sharply to 5.2 per cent from 4.5 per cent projected in April.

“Upward revisions reflect higher global energy prices from the Middle East conflict feeding through to fuel, transport, and food costs across the subregion. India’s FY26 (2026-27) inflation forecast is revised up to 5.2 per cent, driven by higher oil prices and a weaker rupee, with food inflation adding further pressure from heatwaves and fading of favourable base effects,” it said.

The FY28 forecast is retained at 4 per cent as fuel and food prices normalise, supported by favourable base effects, it said.

Last month, RBI too revised down its GDP growth forecast for FY27 to 6.6 per cent from 6.9 per cent, while raising its inflation projection to 5.1 per cent from 4.6 per cent. The ADO has

also lowered its growth forecast for developing Asia and the Pacific economies to 4.9 per cent for 2026 compared to 5.5 per cent growth in 2025.

“This is a reduction of 0.2 percentage points from April projections. Prolonged disruptions to energy markets caused by the Middle East conflict have weighed more heavily on the region’s prospects than anticipated,” it said.

The 2027 growth forecast is maintained at 5.1 per cent, reflecting recovering activity as these pressures ease, it said.

ADO expects disruptions to global energy markets to unwind only gradually, despite a framework agreement signed in June. With impacts extending beyond energy to fertilizers, other commodity prices, and supply chains, inflationary pressures are likely to persist.

Regional inflation is now forecast at 4.3 per cent this year compared to 3 per cent in 2025 - an upward revision of 0.7 percentage points from April. The inflation forecast for 2027 remains at 3.4 per cent, it said.

According to the IMF, the Indian economy is expected to grow at 6.4 per cent in fiscal year 2027, a tad slower than the 6.5 per cent projected in April.

The IMF, in its update to the World Economic Outlook (WEO), projected India to grow at 6.7 per cent in fiscal year 2028, an increase of 20 basis points from the 6.5 per cent growth projected in April.

Rupee rises 1 paisa to 95.47 against dollar



MUMBAI: The rupee appreciated by just 1 paisa to settle at 95.47 against the US dollar on Thursday even as crude oil prices firmed up and the greenback strengthened in global markets.

A recovery in the stock markets and dollar selling by state-run lenders supported the local currency amid rising volatility triggered by the fresh escalation in the West Asia crisis.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened lower by 4 paise at 95.52 against the US dollar and later traded in the range of 95.28 to 95.58 during the day. It settled at 95.47, up 1 paisa from its previous close. The rupee had declined 52 paise to settle at 95.48 against the US dollar on Wednesday.

Analysts said suspected RBI intervention provided support to the local unit, while elevated crude oil prices and a stronger dollar weighed on it.

The dollar index, which gauges the greenback’s strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 100.77, up 0.01 per cent.

Brent crude futures were trading at \$78.40 per barrel, higher by 0.46 per cent. FIIs purchased equities worth Rs 1,962.80 crore on a net basis on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

PTI

Markets rebound on value buying by investors after recent losses

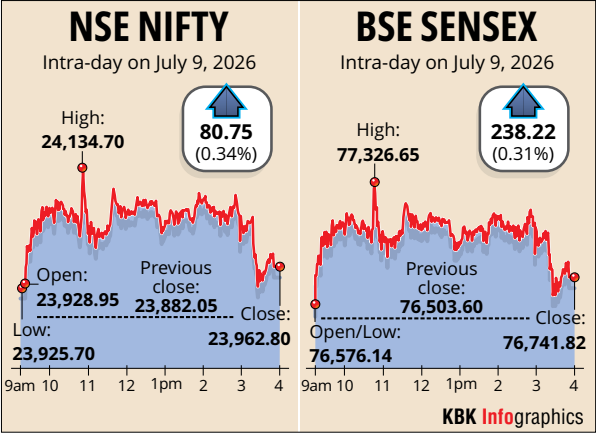
MUMBAI: Stock markets recovered on Thursday, with the benchmark Sensex closing higher by 238 points on broad-based buying by investors after a heavy correction in the previous session.

The 30-share BSE Sensex pared gains due to some profit-taking in the last hour and closed at 76,741.82, up by 238.22 points, or 0.31 per cent.

The 50-share NSE Nifty rose by 80.75 points, or 0.34 per cent, to end at 23,962.80.

Analysts said caution prevailed in the market as the US and Iran exchanged fire for a second consecutive day.

Among Sensex shares, Sun Pharma emerged as the biggest gainer, rising by 2.7 per cent. Bharti Airtel rose by 2.15 per cent, lending major support to the benchmark index. Gains in



Bajaj Finserv, InterGlobe Aviation, Eternal, Kotak Mahindra Bank and HDFC Bank helped Sensex close in the green.

Infosys emerged as the biggest loser, dropping by 1.8 per cent. Maruti, NTPC and Axis

Bank were among the laggards. TCS shares declined by 0.52 per cent.

The BSE SmallCap Select index jumped 1.79 per cent and MidCap Select index climbed 1.39 per cent.

PTI

Gold slips ₹350, silver falls to ₹2,32,000 per kg

NEW DELHI: Gold fell for the fourth straight session, with prices slipping Rs 350 to Rs 1,48,100 per 10 grams in the national capital on Thursday as a strong rupee and sluggish local demand weighed on the precious metal.

The yellow metal of 99.9 per cent purity had closed at Rs 1,48,450 per 10 grams in the previous session.

Silver also extended its losses, falling Rs 7,800 to Rs 2,32,000 per kilogram (inclusive of all taxes) from Wednesday’s closing level of Rs 2,39,800 per kg.

The precious metals declined despite gains in the overseas markets. Traders attributed the weakness to



the appreciation in the rupee against the US dollar, which reduced the cost of imported bullion.

In the international market, spot gold gained \$27.23, or nearly 1 per cent, to \$4,104.75 per ounce, while silver rose more than 1 per cent to trade at \$58.96 per ounce after traders bought bullion following Wednesday’s sharp selloff.

PTI

Vedanta Aluminium enters AMFI large-cap list within weeks of listing

NEW DELHI: Vedanta Aluminium has been classified as a large-cap company in the Association of Mutual Funds in India’s (AMFI) July 2026 half-yearly reclassification, less than a month after becoming an independently listed entity following the Vedanta Group merger.

The inclusion places the company among India’s top 100 firms by average market capitalisation, making it one of the fastest transitions from demerger listing to the large-cap category.

India’s largest primary aluminium producer, with a 46 per cent domestic market share, operates the world’s largest single-location aluminium

smelter at Jharsuguda in Odisha.

Analysts remain positive on the stock, citing rising value-added production, improving cost efficiencies through backward integration and strong earnings growth prospects. Emkay Global has initiated coverage with a Buy rating, while Investec and CLSA have assigned target prices of Rs 630 and Rs 540, respectively, implying potential upside from current levels.

The AMFI classification also makes Vedanta Aluminium eligible for consideration by domestic mutual funds running large-cap mandates. In Q1 FY27, the company reported record aluminium production of 632,000 tonnes, up 5 per

cent year-on-year, despite a sharp decline in London Metal Exchange aluminium prices. It also received an AA+ credit rating with a Stable outlook from ICRA.

The company said its large-cap inclusion reinforces the Vedanta Group’s demerger strategy of creating focused, independently listed businesses. As of June 30, the combined market capitalisation of the group’s five demerged entities stood at about Rs 3.28 lakh crore, compared with Rs 2.14 lakh crore for the unified entity at the beginning of the year.

Vedanta Aluminium now joins Vedanta Ltd and Hindustan Zinc in AMFI’s large-cap universe.

MPOST

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India’s Dedicated Freight Corridor Corporation of India Ltd. (DFCCIL) has embarked on the next phase of its plan to build up its freight infrastructure network with the participation of important industry participants, financiers, and international investors for the new project of the East-West Dedicated Freight Corridor (EWDFC).

This project is a giant railway project that is projected to revolutionise freight operations in the country. This was done through a high-level stakeholders meeting conducted in New Delhi.

The meeting was headed by Praveen Kumar, the Managing Director of DFCCIL, along with Shyam Sundar Gupta, the Rail-



way Board Principal Executive Director for Infrastructure; B. Mugunthan, DFCCIL Director Finance; and Rahul Kapoor, Railway Board Executive Director for Finance/RM & PPP. In addition, several senior officials from DFCCIL were present, including those overseeing infrastructure, operations, and

business development.

According to the officials, discussions revolved around the finance arrangement, construction approach, implementation framework, and involvement process of stakeholders. The officials stated that the interactive process provided an opportunity for the participants to

give their views, ask questions, and identify areas of cooperation during the timely development of the corridor.

Representatives from prominent infrastructure and engineering companies such as Larsen & Toubro, Afcos Infrastructure, Tata Projects, IRCON International, Rail Vikas Nigam Ltd., RITES, G R Infraprojects, Ashoka Buildcon, Megha Engineering & Infrastructures Ltd., Hindustan Construction Company, Kalpataru Projects International, KEC International, GPT Infraprojects, DRA Infracore, and GMR Group were also present in the meeting.

Also, representatives from the logistics and freight sector, including Container Corporation of India (CONCOR), Adani Road Transport and DP World, also participated.

‘₹1 lakh cr investment expected in Tripura’

TARUN CHAKRABORTY

AGARTALA: Tripura is expected to attract investments worth more than Rs 1 lakh crore in the near future, Chief Minister Dr. Manik Saha announced while inaugurating the two-day business conclave, “Destination Tripura,” in Agartala on Thursday.

Addressing delegates from across India and abroad, Dr. Saha invited investors to explore the state’s vast business potential. He highlighted the government’s investor-friendly policies and various incentives aimed at promoting industrial growth, while extending a warm welcome to entrepreneurs and business leaders.

Union Minister for the Development of the North Eastern Region, Jyotiraditya Scindia, addressed the gathering virtually. He elaborated on the Government of India’s Act East Policy and the Ashta Lakshmi initiative envisioned by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, emphasizing the importance of increased investment in the North East.

Union Minister for Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal also encouraged greater industrial investment in the region. Both Union Ministers expressed satisfaction with Tripura’s development and its growing potential as an investment destination.

More than 1,200 industrial delegates are participating in the “Destination Tripura” conclave, which was inaugurated by the Chief Minister in the presence



Tripura Chief Minister Dr. Manik Saha

of members of his Cabinet and senior government officials.

Speaking at the inaugural session, Dr. Saha highlighted Tripura’s strengths, describing it as a resource-rich, power-surplus state with abundant natural gas, bamboo, pineapples, and other agricultural resources.

He also noted that the state now enjoys improved connectivity through enhanced road, rail, and air infrastructure. The Chief Minister described Tripura as the gateway to South Asia, citing its strategic geographical location and expanding connectivity as major advantages for investors.

Among those present at the inaugural ceremony were Ratan Lal Nath, Minister for Power and Agriculture; Pranajit Singha Roy, Finance Minister; Santana Chakma, Industries Minister; and Kishor Barman, Education Minister.

Several Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs) were signed during the event with leading business groups, including ITC, Taj, Techni India Group, and other prominent companies, reflecting strong investor interest in the state.

Jharkhand unveils AI roadmap, plans to invest ₹1,150 cr in next 5 yrs

Roadmap focuses on integrating AI across governance, healthcare, education, agriculture, industry, citizen services

NEW DELHI: The Jharkhand government on July 8, 2026 unveiled a roadmap to position the state as India’s leading public governance-led Artificial Intelligence (AI) hub, outlining plans to invest Rs 1,150 crore over the next five years to strengthen digital infrastructure and AI adoption.

Launched during the National Stakeholders Consultation 2026 in New Delhi, the roadmap focuses on integrating AI across governance, healthcare, education, agriculture, industry and citizen services to improve transparency, efficiency and data-driven

decision-making.

A key proposal is the Jharkhand Artificial Intelligence Policy 2026-2031, which seeks to expand AI use in sectors including mining, environmental management and disaster response while ensuring data privacy, cybersecurity and responsible AI deployment.

The government also proposed the Chief Minister Data Intelligence Platform (CM-DIP), an AI-enabled system for real-time monitoring of government programmes, infrastructure projects and departmental performance. AI-powered citizen services through mul-



tilingual digital platforms, WhatsApp-based service delivery, digital grievance redressal and Panchayat-level access to government services are also planned.

Three flagship AI initiatives - CM-DIP, the Health and Nutrition Vigilance System (HNVS) and the Critical Minerals Administration System (CMAS) - will use data

The govt also showcased plans for a 100.97-acre IT Park in Ranchi to attract GCCs, IT firms and startups

analytics to strengthen governance, healthcare delivery and mineral administration.

As part of its long-term vision, the state plans to establish a State AI Mission, Jharkhand AI Cloud, AI Innovation Hub, AI Park, AI

Innovation Zones, Centres of Excellence and a startup and skilling ecosystem to promote research, innovation and industry-academia collaboration.

The government also showcased plans for a 100.97-acre IT Park in Ranchi to attract Global Capability Centres (GCCs), IT firms and startups. Under Vision 2050, Jharkhand aims to attract over Rs 10,000 crore in investments, establish more than 50 GCCs, support over 1,000 AI startups and create over one lakh AI-enabled jobs, while expanding AI education, skill development and academic partnerships.

MPOST

PARIS HAUTE COUTURE 2026

TEMPLE ART & TEXTILE HERITAGE DEFINE INDIA'S MOMENT

Designers Rahul Mishra and Manish Malhotra showcase the power of Indian craftsmanship



Rahul Mishra Couture Fall 2026 collection, 'Devi'



'Maa' weaves delicate memories of motherhood



Manish Malhotra's Paris Couture debut brings Anna Wintour to the front row



Chinese actress Fan Bingbing walks the runway for Rahul Mishra



Rahul Mishra with Cardi B and Isha Ambani



Manish Malhotra makes his debut at Paris Haute Couture Week

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Long before Indian designers began appearing on the runways of international couture shows, Indian ateliers had already made a name for themselves by creating exquisite craftsmanship for luxury European brands. Today, Indian designers are finally receiving global recognition for that very craftsmanship.

The official Paris Haute Couture calendar remains one of fashion's most exclusive institutions. When India's

celebrated designer Rahul Mishra unveiled 'Devi: The Eternal Muse' at Paris Haute Couture Week, the world took notice. The collection blended modern fashion with India's temple art and sculpture.

According to Mishra, the collection was inspired by the visual language of Indian temple sculptures, particularly the depictions of goddesses, apsaras and celestial figures. The runway featured garments in shades of stone grey, ivory, black, beige and antique gold.

Businesswoman Isha

American rapper Cardi B wore a custom ivory Rahul Mishra couture look inspired by the 'Devi' collection

Ambani attended the show wearing a custom metallic grey Rahul Mishra couture ensemble featuring sculptural embroidery and a sheer draped stole. American rapper Cardi B wore a custom ivory

couture look inspired by the collection. The creation drew inspiration from the 12th-century sculpture of Mohini at the Chennakeshava Temple in Belur. Interestingly, this Kanpur-born designer became the first Indian designer to be invited to present on the official Paris Haute Couture Week calendar in 2020.

Another acclaimed Indian designer, Manish Malhotra, who lost his mother in March 2026, paid tribute to her unwavering faith in him and to his childhood through his collection, 'Maa'. Bring-

ing his signature opulence to Paris Haute Couture Week, Malhotra explored the ideas of protection and liberation through structured silhouettes, fluid drapes and intricate embroidery. The collection merged Indian textile heritage, sentiment and craftsmanship.

His debut couture collection drew a high-profile audience with global fashion powerhouse Anna Wintour seated in the front row. Isha Ambani, Karan Johar and Chinese actress Fan Bingbing were also in attendance.

'It's important that people know me for my work'

Abhishek Banerjee opened up about fans still calling him Compounder

OUR CORRESPONDENT

India's biggest OTT franchise, 'Mirzapur', is all set to script history with 'Mirzapur: The Movie' starring Pankaj Tripathi, Divyendu Sharma and Ali Fazal, becoming the first Indian streaming franchise to make a grand leap to the big screen. The recently released teaser has already created a massive buzz among fans and taken the internet by storm. As anticipation reaches fever pitch, fans are eagerly waiting to reunite with the show's iconic characters who have become pop-culture phenomena over the years.

Among the most beloved is Abhishek Banerjee's Compounder Subodh, a character that continues to enjoy immense popularity. Recently, Abhishek recalled being recognised by a fan as Compounder Subodh, calling it the kind of connection every actor dreams of building with the audience.

"Yes, Jana and Hathoda Tyagi. I think I'm still known more by these characters than by my own name. And I'm genuinely happy about that. When your characters do well, people form that kind of bond with



With its recently released teaser, 'Mirzapur: The Movie' has raised the excitement several notches

them. Just like now, I was walking in and the security guard stopped me and said, 'Arre, Mirzapur compounder!' That's how he remembered me. That's exactly the kind of connection I want to build with my audience," shared Abhishek.

Speaking about his journey as an actor, he added, "It's a long journey ahead; this is just the begin-

ning. For me, it's important that people know me for my work and my acting, not for who I am outside of it. And I'm really grateful for the kind of work that's coming my way."

Further expanding the ensemble, the film features Abhishek Banerjee, Rasika Dugal, Mohitt Maalik, Sheeba Chadha, Rajesh Tailang, Pramod Pathak, Shriya Pilgaonkar, Harshita Shekhar Gaur, Shweta Tripathi and Sonal S Chauhan, coming together to bring to life an epic untold chapter from the world of 'Mirzapur'.

'Mirzapur: The Movie' is presented by 'Amazon MGM Studios' and 'Excel Entertainment'. Directed by Gurmeet Singh, written by Puneet Krishna, and produced by Ritesh Sidhwani and Farhan Akhtar under 'Excel Entertainment' and co-produced by Kassim Jagmagia and Vishal Ramchandani, the film is slated for a grand theatrical release on September 4, 2026.

Bringing the 'bhaukaal' to an even wider audience, 'Mirzapur: The Movie' will be released in Hindi and Telugu.



Saif admits problems with Kartavya's ending

'The villain should have faced consequences,' says Khan

Saif Ali Khan might not be the most reliable actor at the box office, but he is known to be a strong performer who often makes a film-watching experience worthwhile. However, his recent streaming films, 'Kartavya' and 'Jewel Thief', have divided the audience as the films themselves did not live up to expectations. In a recent interview, Saif opened up about how disappointed he was with films like 'Kartavya' and 'Devara', revealing that both films could have benefited from creative decisions that ultimately never materialised.

Speaking to 'The Hollywood Reporter India', he said, "I think I am lucky to have done films like 'Omkaara' and 'Kartavya'. At least you get cast in some of these projects because people think there's perhaps more to you."

"I think I need to attract more of those kinds of films and I want to push myself further at this stage of my career. When I look back at the last couple of years, I realise that

Saif opened up about how disappointed he was with 'Kartavya' and 'Devara'

you survive as an actor. Somebody pays you and that's great. I did 'Devara'. I thought it'd take two months because the role and the pitch sounded exciting, but it ended up taking much longer. Suddenly, you've spent almost a year on one film. Yes, you got paid and maybe it covered one child's education or took care of other responsibilities, but where is the film that makes it all worthwhile? Every film should count. I keep asking myself, 'Why am I doing this?' I am at a stage where I want every next film to matter," he added.

Speaking specifically about 'Kartavya', Saif said, "Kartavya" is fortunate that 'Red Chillies' gave it to 'Netflix' because it was actually completed three years ago."

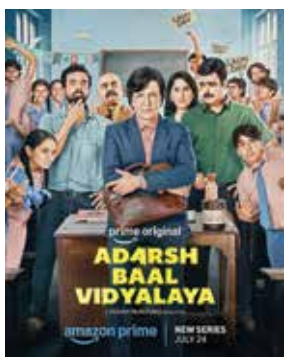


Adarsh Baal Vidyalyaya: An eccentric school's unique story!

OUR CORRESPONDENT

'Prime Video' announced July 24 as the worldwide premiere date of its upcoming 'Prime Original' series, 'Adarsh Baal Vidyalyaya'. Led by the highly versatile Kay Kay Menon, the series also stars Archana Puran Singh, Naveen Kasturia, Prasanna Bisht, Abhimanyu Singh, Deven Bhojani, Ajitesh Gupta, Annapurna Soni and Prachee Shah in pivotal roles.

Set in a dysfunctional school, the series follows Gyaneshwar Tripathi (Kay Kay Menon), a laid-back headmaster whose quest for a coveted government-sponsored training programme in Cambridge sets off an unexpected journey of transformation. As he rallies an unlikely team of teachers to improve the fortunes of one of the city's most underperforming schools, they confront everyday challenges ranging from unruly classrooms and resource shortages to parental



apathy and operational hurdles. The series blends humour with heart, showcasing that even overlooked institutions can aspire to a second chance. 'Adarsh Baal Vidyalyaya' is a warm, spirited comedy about the chaos and contradictions of a system beautifully held together by the sheer perseverance of its people. The storytelling is full of wit, soul and a deeply relatable narrative," said Nikhil Madhok, Director & Head of Originals, 'Prime Video, India'.

AUTHOR



DARSHIM SAXENA

Hindi cinema films Central India most readily when it turns violent. Raja Bundela has spent a career refusing that image

Hindi cinema films Central India most readily when it turns violent. Raja Bundela has spent a career refusing that image.

When Hindi cinema goes looking for central India, it finds the ravine. From Shekhar Kapur's 'Bandit Queen' and Tigmanshu Dhulia's 'Paan Singh Tomar' to Abhishek Chaubey's 'Sonchiriya', the Chambal ravines reach the screen as dust and dacoits. Bundelkhand, beside them, is drawn into the same picture. The best of these films, Dhulia's and Chaubey's, are grave and sympathetic works that blame the state rather than the outlaw. Even so, the region seems most filmable when it turns violent and the 'baaghi' is its passport into the frame.

I have been thinking about one filmmaker from that land who did the opposite. Raja



'Tapra Talkies', the tarpaulin cinema Raja Bundela pitches in Bundelkhand's villages.

PIC/RAJA BUNDELA

Bundela, an actor and director from Lalitpur in Bundelkhand, grew up on the outlaw mythology the movies love. I sat with him recently on 'The Second Seat' and one line stayed with me. He calls his own life a current, not a climb, which is perhaps why he never romanticised the men who climbed out of these ravines with guns. It matters beyond one man. A region the camera keeps reducing to



A place is easiest to film when it is on fire"

violence loses the right to be imagined otherwise and its people are the last to shape the picture.

In 2002, he directed 'Pratha', casting a young Irrfan Khan as the priest who anoints a village girl as a living goddess, a decade before 'Paan Singh Tomar' made the same actor the face of the Chambal dacoit. Bundela's camera went not to the ravine but to the temple. The girl is worshipped in public and used in private, the crime hidden below the shrine that sanctifies it. Where the dacoit film

aims its suspicion at the state and the police, 'Pratha' turned it on the religious power of Bundela's own society. He was assaulted at a Bhopal screening for it, then accused of staging the assault and the film was buried twice over. It remains one of the braver unseen films of that decade.

The refusal didn't stop at 'Pratha'. The film festival he founded at Khajuraho, the 'Tapra Talkies' he carries into villages and the 'Ram Mahotsava' at Orchha all insist on a Bundelkhand of temple, river and devotion rather than ravine, revenge and rupture. He remembers village women in one of those tarpaulin huts weeping through an English film about a trafficked Nepali girl and he took it as proof that the hut was not a compromise but the whole point. He isn't nostalgic about the old defiance, only clear-eyed about its cost. Burn a bus

today, he told me and the bulldozer comes to your house. The fight is now a war of ideas, waged over what a region may see of itself.

That's the real subject of his work. The outlaw's image flatters the outsider's camera because a place is easiest to film when it is on fire. Bundela's cinema makes the slower claim that the people of a place should get to author its picture. Masterpiece or not, it's an argument his part of the country rarely gets to make in its own voice.

Darshim Saxena is a screenwriter and film analyst. She is the founder and host of 'The Second Seat', a long-form conversation platform dedicated to cinema's craft, memory and authorship beyond box-office narratives. Her platform crossed 100K subscribers within 56 days of launch, proving an audience for depth